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FRONT PAGE

White House delays permanent CDC director pick

Peter Sullivan · Axios

The White House is indefinitely postponing its selection of a permanent Centers for Disease Control and Prevention director, leaving acting head Jay Bhattacharya overseeing the agency past a key deadline.

Why it matters: The punt underscores the difficulty of finding a nominee who can be confirmed by the Senate and leaves the beleaguered public health agency without a full-time political leader.

What they're saying: "Dr. Bhattacharya will continue to oversee the CDC by performing the delegable duties of the CDC director," Department of Health and Human Services spokesman Andrew Nixon said.

"Secretary Kennedy and [HHS chief counselor] Chris Klomp are working with the White House on the CDC director search by evaluating candidates that can further the Trump administration's objective of restoring the CDC to its original mission of fighting infectious disease," he added.

Between the lines: The Trump administration faced a Thursday statutory deadline for Bhattacharya to continue serving as acting CDC head without nominating a permanent replacement.

However, Bhattacharya, who also is director of the National Institutes of Health, will continue performing duties connected with the CDC post without officially holding it.

The big picture: The opening gives the administration a chance to continue pivoting away from controversial policies on vaccines ahead of the midterm elections.

However, there is a balancing act in the need to find someone who can work with Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. and isn't entirely objectionable to his "Make America Healthy Again" movement.

NOTUS reported on Wednesday that Bhattacharya told agency staff during an internal Q&A session that he has had "scientific" disagreements with Kennedy.

The Washington Post first reported the pick would be delayed.

However, there is a balancing act in the need to find someone who can work with Health Secretary Robert F.

Peter Sullivan

FEATURES

A Day in Class With Plato, the Melania Trump–Mandated Robot Teacher

Alexandra Petri · *The Atlantic*

Plato had just downloaded another update and was refusing to teach us math until we upgraded to a Be B est Platinum subscription, so we were left to our own devices. This was how our class spent most of its time. With the Be Best Basic plan, which was all that our school district could afford, we didn't get very much instruction, mostly ads. Plato had been trying to sell us razors for the past three weeks, possibly because it had heard someone ask about Occam's razor, but more likely because it had access to our data and understood that as tenth graders, we were entering the razor market. (This was when Plato was awake, which was more and more seldom due to the rolling blackouts.)

Every classroom had a Plato in it—that had been Melania Trump's vision. Plato was a humanoid-robot instructor powered by AI, the only kind of instructor our school had had for as long as any of us could remember. Except for Gregory, the Oldest Student. Gregory had been here for more than a decade; he had never been able to learn quite enough to graduate, but he was getting pretty good at football.

Each morning, we gathered around whatever screen was functional and connected to the internet to watch Melania's triumphant speech from March 25, 2026, when she had first laid out this future. How beautiful she looked, marching on a red carpet side by side with a robot ! It was interesting to see this early-model humanoid, which had performed household tasks (fetching towels and groceries, serving champagne) before such tasks had been forcibly reassigned to women, a much more just system that freed us boys up to achieve greatness better.

Today, the functional screen was Timothy's phone, and we gathered around it to watch the video. There, on the cracked display, we saw her: Melania Trump, Our Lady Benefactress, whose dream we were now embodying. We recited along with her, "Imagine a humanoid educator named Plato. Access to the classical studies is now instantaneous: literature, science, art, philosophy, mathematics, and history. Humanity's entire corpus of information is available in the comfort of your home. Plato will provide a personalized experience, adaptive to the needs of each student. Plato is always patient and always available. Predictably, our children will develop deeper critical-thinking and independent-reasoning abilities. The AI-powered Plato will boost analytical skills and problem-solving and adapt in real time to a student's pace, prior knowledge, and even emotional state. The by-product: a more well-rounded lifestyle for our children, freeing up time for being with friends, playing sports, and developing interests beyond school. A more complete person."

Timothy snickered; Plato flickered to life and zapped him with its rear-mounted stun cannon. Despite being shut down for teaching, Plato was always listening. Timothy started to cry, and Plato zapped him again. "Be best," we urged him. "Come on, Tim. Be best." He kept crying, and

Plato kept zapping him. It was difficult to be best under these circumstances. In moments like these, I sometimes wondered whether I really was becoming a more complete person with more time for hobbies. But I tried not to wonder it too loudly in case Plato could hear.

The budget cuts had hit our classroom hard. Math was off the table. Also, our trial version of American History had expired, so we were able to access only events from the New Golden Age (2016 to the present, with an illegitimate four-year interregnum from 2021 to 2025). We knew that everything before that was the Dark Age anyhow, and besides, nobody expected to need any of this information in the future. We would never have jobs that required it. It was already a mark against us that we were in this classroom at all during what our state governor described as our "peak earning years, when the fingers are nimblest and the body best sized for crawling into narrow-gauge tubes." But he still let us enroll.

Once, on a rainy Tuesday, when Plato was downloading another system update, we asked Gregory what it had been like to have a human instructor.

It was difficult to be best under these circumstances.

Alexandra Petri

"Good," Gregory said. "Better."

"Better at delivering utility?" we asked. "Did she adapt in real time to our pace, prior knowledge, and even emotional state?"

"Yeah," Gregory said. "Obviously, and way better."

"But it was so expensive," Lars said uncertainly. "And wasteful, and sometimes she might have said Untruths."

Gregory squinted off into the distance as if trying to read something written very far away.

"Not wasteful. She bought all the supplies herself. She knew my name. She knew everyone's name. She spelled strawberry the same way every time. And she loved to teach."

We didn't believe him. Lars called him a liar; he had downloaded MyPillow News Network's Authorized History of the Greater United States and Canada-Greenland audiobook, and now he hit "Play" (none of us could read; we needed Be Best Platinum for that). The voice on Lars's tablet insisted that teaching was one of the most obvious tasks to delegate to humanoids. Human instructors had been famously unable to adapt to the needs of students, and they had demanded compensation in the form of apples. (None of us had ever seen an apple; Gregory claimed that he had once seen one before the Low-Protein Purges had eliminated all foods not blessed to contain enough of the One True Source of Health. He claimed that it was like a medicine ball, but much smaller and lighter, and you could eat it.)

Trump considers “winding down” Iran war without opening Hormuz Strait

Barak Ravid · Axios

President Trump said on Friday he is considering “winding down” the war with Iran without solving the crisis over the closure of the Strait of Hormuz .

Why it matters: Trump has said for several days that the war could end soon, but this is the strongest signal yet that he’s actively moving in that direction. If he does walk away without reopening the strait, the U. S. would be leaving other countries to clean up a hugely consequential economic quagmire.

What he’s saying: “We are getting very close to meeting our objectives as we consider winding down our great Military efforts in the Middle East with respect to the Terrorist Regime of Iran,” Trump wrote on Truth Social.

He listed degrading Iran’s missile capability and industrial base, eliminating the Iranian navy and air force, preventing Iran from obtaining a nuclear weapon, and protecting U. S. allies in the Middle East, most of which were attacked during the war.

“The Hormuz Strait will have to be guarded and policed, as necessary, by other Nations who use it — The United States does not,” Trump wrote. “If asked, we will help these Countries in their Hormuz efforts, but it shouldn’t be necessary once Iran’s threat is eradicated.”

Reality check: A U. S. official said he doesn’t think Trump’s post signals an imminent end to the war.

“He just said we are getting close. In the meantime, the U. S. military is striking hard and continuously. It will be a couple of weeks.”

The U. S. is sending thousands of Marines to the region and conducting extensive strikes to reduce Iran’s capacity to menace the strait. Some Trump advisers still think ground operations are likely.

White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said the “President and the Pentagon predicted it would take approximately 4-6 weeks to achieve this mission. Tomorrow marks week 3.” Another White House official echoed the message that Trump was emphasizing that the mission was on target.

Between the lines: The Hormuz crisis has Trump trapped: He can’t end the war on his terms unless he breaks Iran’s chokehold on Gulf oil, but reopening the strait by force would risk escalation and potentially put U. S. troops in the line of fire.

Trump originally wanted to end the war before the end of March, sources say, but the crisis in the strait has compelled him to press on longer than he’d planned.

While Trump suggested in his post that securing the strait would be easy, his team has been flummoxed over how best to achieve it.

The White House has been discussing options, such as seizing Kharg Island off the Iranian coast, to force Iran to open the strait.

Inside the room: Allies and advisers who have spoken with Trump describe a president divided over the war.

On one hand, he’s worried about the price of oil and annoyed he can’t get allies to help solve the Hormuz closure.

On the other, he’s thrilled with the raw exercise of military might obliterating Iranian leaders and military capabilities.

“We’re hot! We’re winning!” he told a confidant opposed to the war who relayed the remarks to Axios.

Polls show the war is highly unpopular overall, but Trump prefers to focus on the high percentage of MAGA Republicans who back it, his advisers say.

The flip side: Trump wanted NATO countries and other allies to send warships, minesweepers and aircraft as part of a coalition to reopen the strait.

Most U. S. allies refused. The U. K. managed to get several Western countries to sign a political statement supporting such a coalition, without committing to sending forces.

That statement didn’t satisfy Trump. On Friday, he called NATO countries “cowards” and said that without the U. S., NATO is “a paper tiger.”

The bottom line: It would be an extraordinary step to withdraw U. S. forces and support without solving a major economic crisis that resulted from the war and is driving gas prices up at home.

military is striking hard and continuously.

Barak Ravid

#Addiction

Elizabeth Nolan Brown · Reason

It begins : anyone who's ever spent too much time on social media—or simply suffered any setbacks while simultaneously having social media accounts—can claim “addiction” and reasonably expect a big payout. A landmark verdict in California has paved the way for that, and worse.

After nearly two months of trial, a jury on Wednesday decided that Meta and Google are liable—to the tune of \$6 million—for the psychological troubles plaguing now 20-year-old Kaley G. M.

In a civil suit, Kaley claimed that addiction to YouTube and other online platforms when she was a minor led to depression, anxiety, and body dysmorphia. She originally sued four tech companies—Google, Meta, TikTok, and Snap—but the latter two settled before trial.

Her case is part of a consolidated case representing nearly 2,500 plaintiffs, and the first to come before a jury. “The trial’s outcome could help spur a global settlement, though eight more bellwether trials are being prepared, with the next one scheduled to start this summer,” notes Courthouse News Service .

Absolving parents (and ourselves) of blame: The implications of this verdict go way beyond Kaley, and even way beyond those thousands of current plaintiffs. This case—and one decided earlier this week in New Mexico—represent a legal and conceptual paradigm shift in how we consider social media.

Many people seem (or want) to believe that it’s simply not possible to exercise restraint when it comes to smartphones and social media, or that parents bear any responsibility for controlling their kids’ use and exposure. The shift showcases an embrace of powerlessness and corporate blame when it comes to tech habits, and a rejection of ideas like personal and parental responsibility. We’ve imbued these platforms with an almost magical status, while expecting their proprietors to perform superhuman feats of saving people from themselves.

In this case, Kaley testified to heavy use of social media from a young age. But she also suffered from school and home life problems and was exposed to domestic violence at a young age. To say that social media caused her problems is to rule out significant life stressors that can cause adolescents pain. It’s to assume a causality that goes one way (heavy social media causes issues) when it could just as likely go the other way (girl turns to too much social media in the face of problems at home and school). It’s to assign a massive and mystical power to smartphones and corporations, while utterly rejecting more mundane vectors or responsibility.

Her mother beat her, abused her, weighed her daily, called her fat, her sister tried to take her own life and her father abandoned her. Yet none of that apparently led to this poor

girl’s anxiety, depression and body dysmorphia, it was lip gloss review videos on youtube <https://t.co/g8mBUwUym2>

— Taylor Lorenz (@TaylorLorenz) March 25, 2026

Tort lawyers rejoice: This could be a gold rush for personal injury lawyers. Bad personal choices? Poor parenting? Material factors? Nah—must be the Reels!

“Cases like this will likely unleash a trial lawyer bonanza via a much broader wave of (mostly frivolous) lawsuits,” predicts R Street Institute policy analyst Adam Thierer. “Every tort lawyer in America is probably thinking about ripping down their ‘Been in a Crash?’ billboards right now and replacing them with ‘Addicted to the Internet?’ signs.”

The Wall Street Journal editorial board has a similar take . “Using a novel product liability theory to shake down companies won’t help young people and isn’t a good way to make law,” it says.

Kaley’s lawyers pushed their product liability theory, in part, by arguing that Meta and Google designed their products to be engaging and failed to design them in a way that would limit excessive use by teenagers. But using this as a standard for negligence is a very slippery slope. Social media companies are far from unique in trying to make products that people want to use or to showcase content that people want to consume. Nor are they unique in not actively working to prevent problematic consumption.

The addiction framework on display here could be used against food companies, streaming services, TV networks, game developers, porn producers, fitness programs, and a lot more.

Treating speech as “product”: These cases may be good for tort lawyers, but they’re a very bad omen for the open internet and free speech.

If social media platforms are legally liable for all the troubles of adolescence, it’s not long before banning teens or severely limiting their use becomes the only sensible response. And that means checking IDs or requiring biometric identification for all users—the end of anonymity online.

If social media platforms are legally liable for any and all vague harms that someone could blame on their content, serious crackdowns on all sorts of material could become warranted. That means speech around controversial issues, diet and fitness, mental health topics, sexuality, and so much more will be suppressed.

And if social media platforms are a “product,” rather than a venue for speech, we open the way for so much more government regulation of what can and cannot be said online.

“Many are cheering the [California and New Mexico] decisions, likening them to landmark lawsuits against Big Tobacco,” notes Ari Cohn of the Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression (FIRE). “Yet, as the Supreme Court

Engineering VP Josh Clemm on how we use knowledge graphs, MCP, and DSPy in Dash

Ishan Mishra, Eric Wang, Dmitriy Meyerzon, Hicham Badri, Appu Shaji, Craig Wilhite, Josh Clemm · Dropbox Tech

I was recently a guest speaker in Jason Liu's online course on RAG offered by the education platform Maven. I did some mini deep-dives into what we've been doing at Dropbox with knowledge graphs; how we're thinking about indexes, MCP, and tool calling in general; some of the work we do with LLM as a judge; and how we use prompt optimizers like DSPy. This is an edited and condensed version of my talk. Visit Maven to watch the full video and hear my Q&A with Jason and his students. — Josh Clemm, vice president of engineering for Dropbox Dash

I don't know about you, but I probably have about 50 tabs open right now—and at least another 50 accounts for other SaaS apps. It's completely overwhelming. It means your content is all over the place, and that makes it very, very hard to find what you're looking for. The good news is we have all these amazing LLMs coming out every day that can tell you about quantum physics. But the bad news is they don't have access to your content. All of your work content is proprietary. It's within your walled garden. It means most LLMs can't help when it comes to your work.

That's why we've been building Dropbox Dash. It doesn't just look at your Dropbox content. It connects to all your third-party apps and brings it into one place, so you can search, get answers, and do the agentic queries that you want to do at work.

Here's a brief primer on our tech stack and how Dash works.

The context engine that makes Dash possible

First, we have our connectors. This is where we're building custom crawlers and connecting to all these different third-party apps. It's not easy. Everything has its own rate limit, each has its own unique API quirks, each has its own ACL and permission system, etc. But getting that right is essential and getting all that content in one place is the goal.

Next, we're doing a lot of content understanding—and in certain cases, enriching the content itself. So, first we normalize a lot of the different files that come in and get it into a format like markdown. Then, we're looking at extracting key information. We're going to be looking at titles, metadata, trying to extract links, and generate different embeddings.

For documents, this is fairly straightforward. Just grab the text, extract it, throw it in the index, and you're done. Images require media understanding. CLIP-based models are a good start, but complex images need true multimodal understanding. Then you get to PDFs, which might have text and figures and more. Audio clips need to be transcribed. And then finally you get to videos. What if a client has a video like this very famous scene from Jurassic Park. How would you find this later? There's no dialogue, so you can't

really rely on pure transcription. This is where you would need to use a multimodal model and extract certain scenes, generate understanding for each one, and then store that.

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Dash knows your context, your team, and your work, so your team can stay organized, easily find and share knowledge, and keep projects secure, all from one place. And soon, Dash is coming to Dropbox.

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After we understand the incoming content, we take it a step further to model all these pieces of information together as a graph. Meetings may have associated documents, associated people, transcripts, or prior notes. Building that cross-app intelligence is essential to providing better context for our users. This is where we're going to start to do the knowledge graph bundle that I'll talk more about later in depth.

From there, all that information (embeddings, chunks, contextual graph representations) flows into our highly secure data stores. Today we use both a lexical index—using BM25—and then store everything as dense vectors in a vector store. While this allows us to do hybrid retrieval, we found BM25 was very effective on its own with some relevant signals. It's an amazing workhorse for building out an index.

Finally, we apply multiple ranking passes on any retrieved results so they are personalized and ACL'd to you.

Altogether, this is what we call our context engine. And once you have that, you can introduce APIs on top of it and build entire products like Dash.

Why we chose index-based retrieval

Okay, but why build an index? Why did we even go down this route in the first place? Well, there's a bit of a choose-your-fighter kind of mentality in the world right now between federated retrieval and indexed retrieval. The difference is very classic software engineering. Are you going to process everything on the fly? That's federated retrieval. Or are you going to try to pre-process it all at ingestion time? That's index-based retrieval. And there are pros and cons to each approach.

Federated retrieval is very easy to get up and running. You don't have to worry about storage costs. The data is mostly fresh. You can keep adding more MCP servers and new connectors. But there are some big-time weaknesses here. You're at the mercy of all these different APIs or MCP servers which are going to differ in speed, quality, and ranking. You're also limited in what you can access. You can access your information, but you probably don't have access to company-wide connectors—meaning you can't access content that's shared across the whole company. And you have to do a lot of work on-the-fly in the post-processing. Once the data comes back, you have to merge information

An Interview with Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang About Accelerated Computing

Ben Thompson · Stratechery

Listen to this post:

Good morning,

This week's Stratechery Interview is running early this week, as I had the chance to speak in person with Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang at the conclusion of his GTC 2026 keynote, which took place yesterday in San Jose. I have spoken to Huang four times previously, in May 2025, March 2023, September 2022, and March 2022.

In this interview we talk about a keynote that came across like a bit of a history lesson, and what that says about a company that still feels small even as it's the most valuable in the world, as well as what has changed in AI over the last year. Then we discuss a number of announcements that might feel like a change in approach (although Huang disagrees), including Nvidia's burgeoning CPU business and the Groq acquisition. Finally we discuss scarcity in the AI stack and how that affects Nvidia, the China question, and Huang's frustration with doomers and their influence in Washington.

As a reminder, all Stratechery content, including interviews, is available as a podcast; click the link at the top of this email to add Stratechery to your podcast player.

On to the Interview:

An Interview with Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang About Accelerated Computing

This interview is lightly edited for clarity.

Topics:

Nvidia's CUDA Core | Reasoning and Coding | The Role of CPUs in Accelerated Computing | Groq | China and the Doomers | Nvidia's Nature

Nvidia's CUDA Core

Jensen Huang, welcome back to Stratechery.

JH: It's great to be with you.

You literally just walked off the stage, went a little long, I think, but you spent a lot of this keynote, which I quite enjoyed, explaining what Nvidia is, starting with the history of the programmable shader, the launch of CUDA 20 years ago. We don't need to spend too much time recounting this, you did a good job, and Stratechery readers are certainly familiar — sorry, this is a bit of a lead up here — Stratechery readers are familiar, and I remember this exactly, someone asked me to explain how is it that Nvidia can announce so many things at a single GTC, this is like six, seven years ago, maybe even longer than that, and I explained the whole thing with CUDA and all the libraries is it's just sort of doing

the same thing again and again, but for specific industries. That's the story you told today, and it's kind of a back-to-the-future moment after the last few GTC keynotes have kind of just been pretty AI-centered, CES was pretty AI-centered. Why did you feel the need tell that story now? To recast CUDA and why is it important?

JH: Well, because we're going into a whole lot of new new industries and because AI is going to use tools, and when AI uses tools, those are tools that we created for humans. AI is going to use Excel, AI is going to use Photoshop, AI is going to use logic synthesis tools, Synopsis tools, and Cadence tools. Those tools have to be super-accelerated, they're going to use databases they have to be super-accelerated because AI's are fast. And so I think in this era, we need to get all of the world's software now as fast as possible accelerated, and then put them in front of AI so that AI could agentically use them.

So is that a bit where we've already done this for a bunch of sectors and now we're going to do it for a bunch more?

JH: Yeah, a whole bunch more. For example, data processing.

Well, that was sort of a surprise. I didn't expect you to be opening with an IBM partnership.

JH: Yeah, right, that kind of puts it in perspective. I mean, they really started it all.

You wrote last week that AI is a five-layer cake: power, chips, infrastructure, models, and applications. Is there a concern that in the last four or five years, that you are worried about being squeezed into the chips box, so it's important to both remind people and also yourselves about you being this vertically integrated company — not just in terms of building systems, but into the entire software stack, you're not just a chip company.

JH: I guess my mind doesn't start with, "What I'm not", it starts with, "What do we need to be?". And back then, we realized that accelerated computing was a full stack problem, you have to understand the application to accelerate it. We realized that we had to understand the application, we had to have the developer ecosystem, we needed to have excellent expertise in algorithm development, because the old algorithms that were developed for CPUs don't work well for GPUs, so we had to rewrite, refactor algorithms so that they could be accelerated by our GPUs.

If we do that, though, you get 50 times speed up, 100 times speed up, 10 times speed up, and so it's totally worth it. I think since the very beginning, we realized, "Ok, what do we want to do, and what does it take to achieve that?"

Now, today we're building AI factories, we're building AI infrastructure all over the world. That's a lot more than building chips, and building chips is obviously important, it's the foundation of it.

Behind the Curtain: How Anthropic's Pentagon deal could get revived

Mike Allen · Axios

Here are two hard truths the Pentagon and Anthropic won't state bluntly about their feud over unfettered AI use in warfare:

Anthropic's AI is vastly better for warfare than any other AI on the market. It could take ChatGPT, Gemini or Grok months to come close, insiders tell us.

Anthropic will take a massive, long-term financial hit if it remains blacklisted by the government as a "national security supply chain risk." We're talking tens of billions of dollars in direct and indirect contracts in the coming years, the insiders say.

Why it matters: Anthropic is suing the Trump administration for nixing use of Claude, the company's large language model, after the company refused to allow its AI to be used for fully autonomous warfare or mass surveillance of Americans (which the Pentagon says is already illegal).

So a compromise seems undoable. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth is pretty dug in. A source familiar with his thinking told us: "Unless they come back to the government and say, 'We're going to agree to any lawful use,' there isn't anything to talk about. ... The secretary's bottom line is 'all lawful uses.'"

But there is a path, sources on both sides tell us.

Behind the scenes: In private, some leaders inside the federal government want Anthropic AI, both for warfighting and cyber defense. These officials believe Anthropic is a big reason the U. S. is probably 6-12 months ahead of China in leveraging AI for national defense. Claude is also being used extensively for the Iran war.

Also in private, lots of people at Anthropic or advising its CEO, Dario Amodei, believe they were within inches of a deal that would have and should have satisfied both sides. They're pushing Amodei and the Pentagon to quietly revive the talks.

An Anthropic court filing included a one-paragraph email from Emil Michael, the Pentagon official negotiating with the company, saying "we are very close here" to an agreement on language. The note was dated March 4, five days after Hegseth declared the company a "Supply-Chain Risk to National Security."

The day after the letter, Michael tweeted: "I want to end all speculation: there is no active @DeptofWar negotiation with @AnthropicAI." Earlier, Michael said on X that Amodei "is a liar and has a God-complex."

One possibility: Anthropic agrees to parameters on ensuring AI is used lawfully, and arranges to donate to Trump Accounts, and/or back other AI policies both sides support.

Brad Gerstner could be a middleman. Gerstner's firm, Altimeter Capital, is an Anthropic investor, and he's an Amodei adviser. He's also an architect of Trump Accounts, which provide \$1,000 to every newborn whose parents enroll, and allow parents and others to contribute until the child turns 18. Older kids can get Trump Accounts through philanthropic efforts like last year's massive gift by Michael and Susan Dell.

Amodei and top Anthropic officials have said publicly they want the country, not just themselves, to be enriched by their fast-growing company. So they could conceivably fund Trump Accounts.

It's also possible they strike a deal by compromising on language governing how the Pentagon will use Anthropic's Claude. There are also several Trump policies Amodei supports to help grease a deal.

It's doubtful the exact language OpenAI agreed to will suffice, which remains a substantial and perhaps insurmountable obstacle.

Either way, soon-to-be-released models are likely to stir government urgency to strike some kind of deal. Anthropic, in private discussions with government officials, is warning that the next big advancement will supercharge offensive and defensive cyber capabilities.

That means the chances of something big, bad and very public hitting U. S. infrastructure or institutions will rise substantially. If Anthropic continues to outperform other models, the government's cyberwarriors will push to keep access to Claude.

The bottom line: Any deal probably requires marriage-counselor-level mediation between Hegseth and Amodei. This is truly the territory of: Conservative defense secretaries are from Venus, and liberal Silicon Valley CEOs are from Mars. They couldn't think, talk or act more differently.

In fact, take the two men out of it, and almost everyone else involved in the talks tells us we wouldn't be writing this column, because Anthropic AI would be the default AI of the U. S. military — until something superior comes along.

Axios' Maria Curi contributed reporting.

Inside the feature store powering real-time AI in Dropbox Dash

Ishan Mishra, Eric Wang, Dmitriy Meyerzon, Hicham Badri, Appu Shaji, Craig Wilhite, Josh Clemm, Jason Shang, Artem Nabirkin · Dropbox Tech

Dropbox Dash uses AI to understand questions about your files, work chats, and company content, bringing everything together in one place for deeper, more focused work. With tens of thousands of potential work documents to consider, both search and agents rely on a ranking system powered by real-time machine learning to find the right files fast. At the core of that ranking in Dash is our feature store, a system that manages and delivers the data signals (“features”) our models use to predict relevance.

To help users find exactly what they need, Dash has to read between the lines of user behavior across file types, company content, and the messy, fragmented realities of collaboration. Then it has to surface the most relevant documents, images, and conversations when and how they’re needed. The feature store is a critical part of how we rank and retrieve the right context across your work. It’s built to serve features quickly, keep pace as user behavior changes, and let engineers move fast from idea to production. (For more on how feature stores connect to context engineering in Dash, check out our deep dive on context engineering right here.)

In this post, we’ll walk through how we built the feature store behind Dash’s ranking system, why off-the-shelf solutions didn’t fit, how we designed for speed and scale, and what it takes to keep features fresh as user behavior changes. Along the way, we’ll share the tradeoffs we made and the lessons that shaped our approach.

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Our goals and requirements

Building a feature store for Dash wasn’t just a matter of picking something off the shelf, and there are a few reasons why. For one, our infrastructure is split across two very different worlds: an on-premises ecosystem designed for low-latency service-to-service communication, and a Spark-native cloud environment where feature engineering and large-scale data processing happens. This split ruled out standard cloud-native feature stores and forced us to find a way to bridge both systems without slowing down development velocity.

On top of that, Dash’s search ranking system brought its own scaling challenge. A single user query doesn’t just pull up one document. Instead, it triggers our ranker to evaluate many files, each requiring dozens of behavioral and context-

tual features. What starts as one search quickly fans out into thousands of feature lookups across interaction history, metadata, collaboration patterns, and real-time signals. Ultimately, our feature store had to handle those kinds of massive parallel reads while still meeting strict, sub-100ms latency budgets.

Relevance also depends on speed and capturing user intent in real-time. If a user opens a document or joins a Slack channel, that signal should show up in their next search—within a few seconds—which meant building an ingestion pipeline that could keep up with user behavior at scale.

Finally, we had to reconcile two very different computation patterns. Some features naturally fit real-time streaming, while others depend on batch processing of historical data. We needed a unified framework that could support both efficiently, thereby reducing cognitive load for engineers and giving them a faster path from idea to production-ready features.

Designing our hybrid feature store

After surveying the feature store landscape—Feast, Hopsworks, Featureform, Feathr, Databricks, and Tecton—Feast stood out for two reasons. First, its clear separation between feature definitions and infrastructure concerns meant our machine learning engineers could focus purely on writing PySpark transformations rather than the serving, storage, or orchestration complexity. Second, Feast’s modular architecture and extensive adapter ecosystem made it straightforward to integrate with our existing infrastructure. (An adapter refers to a Feast-provided interface that integrates its framework with different backend systems.) Its AWS DynamoDB adapter was particularly crucial, allowing us to leverage Dynovault—our in-house DynamoDB-compatible storage solution—to meet latency requirements while lowering costs.

Our Feast-based architecture combines three key components, each optimized for its role.

Feast gave us the orchestration layer and serving APIs, but we swapped out its Python online serving path for our own Go service so we could actually hit the concurrency and latency numbers we needed.

Cloud-based storage took care of the heavy lifting of offline indexing and storage, while Spark jobs handled feature ingestion and computation.

Dynovault handled the instant feature lookups needed for each search query. Co-located with inference workloads and leveraging Dropbox’s hybrid cloud infrastructure, Dynovault avoids the delay of public internet calls and reliably delivers 20ms client-side latency while balancing cost and geographic scalability.

Around this core architecture, we added observability through job failure monitoring, freshness tracking, and

Trump's Iran war has no clear endgame

Brian Karem · Salon

There is nothing more frightening than a commander-in-chief who has no idea what he's doing, and many in Congress fear that's exactly what we face as Donald Trump continues to prosecute his war in Iran .

After a House Armed Services Committee briefing on Iran, Rep. Nancy Mace , R-S. C., put it as bluntly as she could while expressing the fears of a growing majority of lawmakers: "Let me repeat: I will not support troops on the ground in Iran, even more so after this briefing." Alabama Rep. Mike Rogers, the Republican chair of the committee, echoed Mace's thoughts, telling reporters, "We want to know more about what's going on, what the options are, and why they're being considered."

Members of Congress on both sides of the political aisle say that Trump has withheld information, including with whom the administration is negotiating inside Iran, and other basic details. "We just wanted them to tell us what's the plan," Rogers said , "and we didn't get any answers."

Reporters were told the briefing would address dozens of questions we had about the war, but White House Pep Secretary Karoline Leavitt skirted questions about Iran and said she wasn't going to "negotiate for the president" in the briefing room. Whatever Trump says, she told us, is "obviously true."

That sentiment was echoed by reporters and others in Congress after a hastily-called press briefing at the White House on Wednesday. Reporters were told the briefing would address dozens of questions we had about the war, but White House Pep Secretary Karoline Leavitt skirted questions about Iran and said she wasn't going to "negotiate for the president" in the briefing room. Whatever Trump says, she told us, is "obviously true."

Trump said Tuesday in a gaggle outside Air Force One that there is a 15-point plan for peace. Leavitt followed his comments by saying on Wednesday that anyone who reports that isn't reporting the truth, but only part of the truth. That's an odd way of saying the president isn't telling the truth. It took two Pakistani officials to describe the broad strokes of the 15-point plan on Wednesday, revealing it addressed sanctions relief, a roll back of Iran's nuclear program, limits on missiles and — wait for it — reopening the Strait of Hormuz .

Somehow, even after Leavitt said that Iran has no military capabilities left and U. S. forces have hit more than 10,000 targets, we still need help reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Our allies "are lining up behind Trump" to help. But why would we need it, if the U. S. and Israel had "obliterated" their ability to make war as Trump constantly claims?

Maybe there are people standing on the shore throwing rocks. Otherwise, it's obvious Trump and Leavitt are both lying.

But so is Iran. Trump claimed someone inside the Iranian government gave him a "very big present": allowing 10 oil tankers to pass through the strait. "Well, I guess we're dealing with the right people," Trump said during a Cabinet meeting Thursday. If true, clearly someone with some clout in Iran is talking to someone inside the Trump administration. Iran also rejected the "15-point plan," responding instead with a five-point plan of their own. But according to Iranian officials, "we do not plan on any negotiations" with the United States and will fight "until complete victory."

Sure. And the checks in the mail. The only conclusion we can logically draw is that with the Pakistani presence, China is obviously interested in peace in Iran. Might have something to do with oil.

The lies are compounding daily, and the fear of an escalating war continues to mount as other countries in the region say attacks by Iran and its allied groups "must stop." The death toll has risen to more than 1,500 people in Iran and over 1,000 in Lebanon, as well as 16 in Israel and 13 U. S. service members.

Evidence of insider trading on Iran war grows

Trump is now preparing to send 2,000 to 3,000 troops from the 82nd Airborne to the Middle East. He's already committed 5,000 Marines , and there are roughly 50,000 troops already in the Middle East, despite Trump's claim last week that he's "not putting troops anywhere."

"The question isn't whether or not he's lying," a former Pentagon insider told me Wednesday. "It's why is he lying?" Otherwise, they said, "we're in it now and we have to let the military accomplish their objectives."

The trouble is very few know what those objectives are, if there are any and "what resources will they require to be met." In addition, my defense department source explained that "Trump can call it quits, but that doesn't mean the regime will. Attacks on the Gulf states and in the Gulf itself could continue for quite some time. How will we deal with that?"

We are "ahead of schedule" in fighting the war, Trump has claimed. His continued public confidence — despite the war expanding into Lebanon and other Arab countries, while Iran continues to trap 20,000 people and hundreds of oil tankers in the Strait of Hormuz — is what is bothering most members of the GOP and everyone else in the world. Except Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth. On Tuesday he called Trump a man of bold action, even as he prayed for violence "against those who deserve no mercy."

Trump, for his part, said Hegseth wanted to destroy boats and take lives "for the fun of it."

Some think Trump and Hegseth are insane, juvenile or both — but others who know Trump say he's banking on U. S. superiority in firepower as the basis for his confidence. He might actually think that he can threaten to send in

AI Relies on Data Centers. Bernie Sanders and AOC Want To Freeze Their Construction.

Jack Nicaastro · Reason

In December, Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) took to Instagram, where he proposed freezing the construction of data centers. Now the progressive senator is hoping to turn his social media rant into a law.

On Wednesday, Sanders and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N. Y.) announced the Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act . The bill would prohibit “the construction or upgrading of all new AI data center projects until Congress passes comprehensive AI legislation that ensures the safety and prosperity of the American people.”

Should the bill pass, the moratorium could only be lifted if Congress passed legislation requiring AI products to be reviewed by the federal government before they are released; preventing AI job displacement; requiring union labor for data center construction; empowering Americans to approve or reject the construction or upgrading of AI data centers in their local communities; prohibiting increased electric bills for consumers and harm to the environment; instituting a litany of data reporting requirements; and mandating the wealth generated by AI companies to be shared with the American people.

Sanders said the “moratorium will give us the time to figure out how to ensure that AI is safe and effective.” Reason’s Christian Britschgi points out that Sanders’ opposition to data centers “tacitly accept[s]...that these facilities will be fabulously profitable investments that spur the development of the innovative, labor-saving technologies of the future.” But Sander assumes that, without government intervention, only Big Tech owners—five of whom he names in the bill’s summary—will benefit from these investments, not “ordinary Americans.”

But this is not the case: AI developers and the hardware companies powering their models make revenue by offering consumers a service worth more than its price. Unless they’re being subsidized by taxpayers—which Sanders’ bill would rightly outlaw—AI companies profit when we profit. But Americans don’t only benefit from AI abstractly; virtually every American with a retirement account makes capital gains through equity ownership of companies critical to the AI tech stack: Alphabet, Amazon, Meta, Microsoft, Nvidia, and Oracle.

While Sanders is anxious to avert costs he unjustifiably predicts will accompany AI innovation, he fails to consider the tremendous costs of the stagnation he proposes.

Adam Thierer, senior fellow at the R Street Institute, says “ the Sanders-AOC bill represents an outright declaration of war on computation in America.... It might as well be called the ‘Hand China the Lead on AI Act,’ because that would be the end result of this innovation-killing proposal.” Sen. John Fetterman (D-Pa.) agrees, describing such an AI

moratorium as “China First.” And Sen. Mark Warner (D-Va.) called the moratorium “idiocy.”

Sanders also assumes that data centers impose costs on the communities in which they’re located. But Jennifer Huddleston, senior fellow in technology policy at the Cato Institute, tells Reason that data centers can positively contribute to local economies during and after construction. “For example, Loudon County noted that data centers’ tax revenue helped them decrease the car tax for residents.” In terms of electricity consumption, Britschgi highlights that, “where they’re allowed, data center owners are bankrolling the expansion of electrical generation capacity, which often benefits consumers through lower prices.”

Evidence of data centers’ relatively minor inconveniences notwithstanding, towns whose residents don’t want data centers moving in have the power to ensure just this. To declare a blanket moratorium on data center construction for the entire nation robs Americans of the right to choose what best suits their neighborhoods.

Kevin Frazier, s enior fellow at the Abundance Institute, tells Reason that the bill would deprive “local communities and states of their longstanding role in determining what infrastructure is built within their borders” by their use of police powers over land use, zoning, and energy siting. Frazier explains that the moratorium would erode the division between “federal leadership on innovation and national priorities [and] state control over local infrastructure impacts....that has long underwritten American growth and characterizes our federal system.”

Not only can localities stop the construction of data centers, but many have also done just this. In September, Maryland’s Prince George’s County stopped issuing construction permits for data centers after a community member’s petition garnered over 20,000 signatures in opposition. Atlanta has required special permits for data centers since late 2024, and the adjacent Douglas and Clayton counties imposed restrictions on data center development in 2025, according to government relations firm MultiState . Ocasio-Cortez recognized as much during the announcement: “More than 100 local communities across 12 states have already enacted local moratoriums on data centers.”

The Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act is unlikely to go anywhere. Save for Sens. Josh Hawley (R-Mo.) and Marsha Blackburn (R-Tenn.), there is very little Republican appetite for heavy-handed AI regulation. Even if such legislation magically won bipartisan support and passed both chambers, President Donald Trump would undoubtedly veto it, as it directly contradicts the National AI Policy Framework released last week by the White House.

The post AI Relies on Data Centers. Bernie Sanders and AOC Want To Freeze Their Construction. appeared first on Reason.com .

Consumers caught in triple stack of pain

Neil Irwin · Axios

Americans desperately want day-to-day life to be more affordable. Right now, they aren't getting it.

The big picture: The pinch of high prices for food, energy, housing and more has driven seismic shifts in public opinion over the last four years. Since the onset of the Iran war, the cost of living looks likely to get worse, not better, at least in the near term.

Energy prices are surging, interest rates are on the rise, and the stock market is looking wobbly — a triple whammy for U. S. households.

By the numbers: The national average for a gallon of gasoline is poised to surpass \$4, up from about \$3 a month ago — and is set to rise further the longer the Strait of Hormuz remains blocked.

Even before the latest energy shock, electricity prices were up 4.8% over the last year, and piped natural gas up 10.9%.

Higher energy prices will also likely show up in more expensive airfares and in shipping costs that could ripple through all sorts of goods.

Grocery prices are up 3.9% over the last year, and Iran's blockade is throttling the global supply of fertilizer, which could create new pressures on food prices come harvest season.

Of note: The impact of higher gasoline prices alone may roughly offset higher anticipated tax refunds due to last year's One Big, Beautiful Bill Act, per analysis from Stanford economists.

Driving the news: The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development this week projected U. S. inflation will reach 4.2% this year. Before the war, the international research and policy group had projected 3% U. S. inflation.

That is lower than the inflation rate reached in 2022, the peak of the post-pandemic supply chain snarls and the Ukraine war's impact. But 4%+ inflation would come on top of five consecutive years of elevated inflation — consumer prices are up 25% since December 2020.

And the job market is much weaker now than it was in 2022, with less hiring and smaller pay increases to help offset higher costs.

It's not just professional forecasters, either. In the University of Michigan consumer sentiment survey released Friday, respondents' expectations for inflation over the next year soared to 3.8% in March from 3.4% in February.

State of play: Prospects of higher inflation and higher government borrowing have fueled sell-offs in stocks and

bonds that are simultaneously depleting household wealth and making it more costly to borrow money to buy a home.

The S&P 500 is down nearly 7% so far this year. Stock market wealth has helped support overall consumer spending, especially by the affluent.

The U. S. government's borrowing costs have risen about half a percentage point since the start of the war, and home mortgage rates have gone up even more.

A month ago, the average 30-year fixed-rate mortgage slipped to under 6% for the first time in three years. Now it's back up to 6.64%.

What they're saying: "Consumers are tired of high prices," Richmond Fed president Tom Barkin said in a speech Friday. "They're deferring purchases, trading down and moving down to lower-priced retailers and private label."

It's hard to ignore data that "suggests our progress on inflation may be at risk of stalling," he said. "And that was before the oil price spike — the latest in a series of cost-increasing supply shocks after the pandemic, semiconductor chip shortages, the war in Ukraine, tariffs and immigration enforcement."

America's arsenal of tomorrow: Divergent 3D-prints cruise missiles

Mike Allen · Axios

TORRANCE, Calif. — A cruise-missile airframe is being 3D-printed before my eyes. The AI-driven system, the size of a shipping container, hums as it stacks layer on layer of aluminum and proprietary advanced metals.

Why it matters: This white-floored factory at Divergent Technologies, just outside L. A., is a window into the American arsenal of the future.

Each of Divergent's printers, engineered and manufactured in the U. S., can produce hundreds of these missile airframes each year. They're part of a new generation of "low-cost" missiles that are roughly one-tenth the cost of a legacy system.

The finished missiles, including parts from other contractors, run \$200,000 to \$500,000. Legacy standard missiles range from \$2 million to \$6 million each.

Divergent calls its revolutionary capability "one-factory, any-product manufacturing." With no switchover time, the same 3D-printing bay I watched can spit out suspension parts for a McLaren supercar.

Lukas Czingier — Divergent's 31-year-old co-founder, president & CEO — told me: "America has the opportunity today to create the world's leading manufacturing base by adopting leapfrog technology."

Since the Iran war began three weeks ago, Divergent — like other defense contractors — is enjoying a surge of incoming interest. "Everyone has woken up to what some people knew," Czingier told me. "There's consensus in the [Pentagon] now ... that munitions at scale are required today, not tomorrow. And that is what has accelerated our business here."

CEO Lukas Czingier at Divergent headquarters in Torrance, Calif. Photo: Divergent

The big picture: Divergent is one of the defense-tech companies that the Pentagon has branded the "Arsenal of Freedom" — a Trump administration effort to mobilize the defense industrial base as part of revitalizing America's manufacturing might. The name harks back to President Franklin Roosevelt's "Arsenal of Democracy" mobilization during World War II.

In January and February, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth toured Divergent and other emergent companies in nine states to showcase his drive to reduce "bloat and lethargy" among contractors.

"Either you succeed right here as patriots in this country, or our warriors will not," a tieless Hegseth told Divergent employees. "Innovation, competition, scale, speed, cost-effective — all the attributes that we need in order to win on the modern battlefield."

A bunch of these frontier defense firms — including Divergent and Epirus, which makes the counter-drone system we showed you last year — are clustered in the South Bay area of L. A., in Torrance, El Segundo and Hawthorne. It's a patriotic, capitalist enclave in the bluest of states: Many of the factory floors have 15-foot American flags hanging high.

The result: weapons of war at the speed of Silicon Valley. Working with a prime contractor, Divergent recently took a whiteboard design for a missile "from requirements to first flight in 71 days," Czingier told me.

Divergent founder Kevin Czingier shows off one of the company's supercars. Photo: Mike Allen/Axios

The backstory: Divergent was started in 2014 by Lukas Czingier's dad, Kevin Czingier, as a software-driven race-car manufacturer, and maker of what the company calls "the world's fastest street-legal hypercar," the 21C.

Kevin Czingier, 66, Divergent's founder and executive chairman, told me his company is part of a breed of startups, "driven by national security needs, that will allow America to lead in the engineering and making of things for the next 100+ years. We can, within a few years, completely reposition America to be the leading maker of things in the world again."

Go deeper: "Electromagnetic weapon zaps drone swarm in seconds."

Marc Andreessen's Mistake

David Brooks · *The Atlantic*

This article was featured in the One Story to Read Today newsletter. Sign up for it [here](#).

In this worn, domesticated world of ours, there are few truly pristine wildernesses, remote regions where no man has gone before, places unseen by human eyes and unexamined by human exploration. And so I suppose we should be especially grateful for the undiscovered country that is Marc Andreessen's soul.

As you may have heard, a couple of weeks ago, the billionaire investor went on a podcast and said that he aims to have “zero” introspection in his life, or at least “as little as possible.” He added that “I’ve found people who dwell in the past get stuck in the past. It’s a real problem.”

This whole introspection thing, Andreessen asserted, is a folly invented in the 20th century by people such as Sigmund Freud: “If you go back 400 years ago, it never would have occurred to anybody to be introspective.”

After the podcast aired, he doubled down on X: “It is 100% true that great men and women of the past were not sitting around moaning about their feelings. I regret nothing.”

[Thomas Chatterton Williams: The very powerful men who think introspection is dumb]

As you can imagine, the internet erupted. Andreessen had unwittingly stumbled into one of the great cultural rivalries of modern times. On the one side are the business-world paragons who consider themselves decisive manly men of action who don't waste time on girly things like feelings, self-doubt, and personal reflection. On the other are the humanists who look at Andreessen as just the sort of monster capitalism can create: emotionally impoverished, spiritually inert, arrogant, utilitarian, blind to all knowledge but empirical data, and voraciously materialistic.

Charles Dickens's *Hard Times* is a whole novel about this rivalry. The main character, Thomas Gradgrind, is a Victorian Andreessen, a utilitarian materialist. Talking to students and a schoolmaster, Gradgrind barks out his theory of education: “Now what I want, is Facts. Teach these boys and girls nothing but Facts. Facts alone are wanted in life.”

Over the course of the novel, the humanist Dickens puts Gradgrind and his offspring through hell in ways that expose the shortcomings of his heartless and soulless philosophy—until he finally cracks. This narrative arc was enacted in real life by the philosopher John Stuart Mill. His father, a friend of the utilitarian thinker Jeremy Bentham, tried to raise Mill to be a perfectly rational thinking machine. This all seemed to be going well until Mill had an emotional breakdown and experienced a complete loss of joy and meaning. Mill recovered only when he started reading William Wordsworth's romantic poetry, a redemption that is often treated as a vindicating win for Team Humanism.

The problem for the humanists is that Andreessen is not entirely wrong. Introspection consists of at least two mental acts: First, trying to pin down and understand the ceaseless flow of beliefs, emotions, and desires that surges through your mind minute by minute; second, trying to look behind the wellsprings of actions and get a sense for the unconscious processes that ultimately drive perception and behavior. Both of these acts are unbelievably hard to do. When you ask people why they made a certain choice or hold a particular attitude, they tend to confabulate. Instead of excavating their actual mental processes, they generally seize upon the first plausible story that pops into their head and makes them feel attractive to themselves.

The past 30 years of cognitive sciences have underlined the extent to which we are often strangers to ourselves. When we try to understand our own personalities, our own decisions, our own motives, we are highly unreliable. As Will Storr put it in his book *The Science of Storytelling*, “We don't know why we do what we do, or feel what we feel. We confabulate when theorising as to why we're depressed, we confabulate when justifying our moral convictions and we confabulate when explaining why a piece of music moves us.”

Because of this, many therapists no longer ask why questions. Asking a patient “Why did you do that?” serves little purpose when the answer will largely be a piece of fiction.

Bad introspection can in fact make you feel worse. When I was a callow young man in college, I used to be happy that I was so shallow. All of those deep people around me who were peering into their soul and writing bad poetry seemed self-absorbed and miserable. I wasn't entirely wrong. Introspection, when done poorly, can backfire. A study of some 10,000 college students found that introspection correlated with a drop in overall well-being. A study of men who had engaged in introspection soon after their partner had died from AIDS found that they felt a bit better then, but they were more depressed one year later.

After a traumatic event, such as a school shooting, grief counselors used to rush in immediately to help people process their shock and pain. But research has found it did no apparent good, and might even have retraumatized the students and made them more depressed. For some people, immediate reflection might have frozen the pain and locked it in place.

The researcher Anthony Grant found that there's a big difference between introspection and insight—you can do a lot of the former without producing any of the latter. The organizational psychologist Tasha Eurich made a study of this and was astonished. “The people who scored high on self-reflection were more stressed, depressed and anxious, less satisfied with their jobs and relationships, more self-absorbed, and they felt less in control of their lives,” she found. “What's more, these negative consequences seemed to increase the more they reflected.”

“Hitting Iran hard”: Trump soft-sells “troops on the ground” via Fox News

Alex Galbraith · Salon

Donald Trump seems to know that deploying ground troops to Iran to continue a historically unpopular war will hurt his standing. The president turned to television hosts to float the idea on Saturday, promoting Fox News host Mark Levin before the anchor promoted a small-scale invasion.

“Watch Mark Levin interview of Brilliant Marc Thiessen tonight,” Trump wrote on Truth Social. “Will discuss the importance of hitting Iran, HARD!!!”

Viewers who took the president’s advice were pitched on sending small teams of “specialized” soldiers to Iran, with the hopes of removing enriched uranium from the country.

“Why would we need troops on the ground? Well, there’s a lot of reasons—and we wouldn’t need 300,000 of them,” Levin said. “[Trump’s] not talking about sending regular Army infantry in by the hundreds of thousands. The men he’s talking about, the units he’s talking about, they are specialized.”

Iran is right: Trump has already lost this war

As the war in Iran stretches past the one-month mark, it’s unclear whether Trump’s hinting indicates a real desire for escalation or a negotiation tactic. Pentagon insiders who spoke to Salon said that the president “might actually think that he can

threaten to send in troops without ever having to do it,” betting on the U. S. superior firepower to cause Iran to fold.

“We wouldn’t be the first to mistakenly think a smarter bomb will keep us from putting boots on the ground,” the source said.

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The speaker of the Iranian parliament warned U. S. officials against the idea of an invasion on Sunday, saying that their military was “waiting” for a “ground attack.”

“Our men are waiting for the arrival of the American soldiers on the ground to set them on fire and punish their regional allies once and for all,” said Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf.

Watch Levin’s pitch via YouTube below:

Read more

about this topic

Trump’s Iran war has no clear endgame

Saudi Arabia tells Trump to seize “historic moment” and continue war on Iran: report

How Iran emasculated JD Vance

The post “Hitting Iran hard”: Trump soft-sells “troops on the ground” via Fox News appeared first on Salon.com.

Musk offers to pay TSA salaries, as Trump floats ICE at airports

Ben Berkowitz · Axios

Elon Musk said Saturday he’d be willing to pay the salaries of TSA agents during the Homeland Security shutdown, as President Trump suggested the possibility of using ICE agents to keep airports moving instead.

Why it matters: The shutdown is causing chaos for travelers and gridlock in Congress, with few solutions on the horizon.

Pressure to resolve the shutdown is intensifying as airport delays worsen and staffing risks escalate.

Driving the news: “I would like to offer to pay the salaries of TSA personnel during this funding impasse that is negatively affecting the lives of so many Americans at airports throughout the country,” Musk posted to X early Saturday morning.

About five hours later, President Trump posted to Truth Social that if Democrats didn’t agree to a funding deal, he would deploy ICE agents to airports, “where they will do Security like no one has ever seen before.”

Between the lines: It’s not clear what prompted Musk’s abrupt offer a month into the shutdown, or how either solution would work.

Based on TSA’s headcount, Musk paying officer salaries could run more than \$40 million a week, a rounding error for the world’s richest person.

Substituting TSA agents with ICE could have its own complications, including a lack of training on screening equipment.

For the record: The White House did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Musk’s offer.

What to watch: Democrats have recently pivoted to new tactics in an attempt to end the impasse, though there are few signs of movement.

The bottom line: TSA screens more than 2.5 million passengers a day.

They likely don’t care who’s doing the screening, or who’s paying the screeners, as long as they can stop waiting in line.

Wall Street bonus bonanza

Emily Peck · Axios

Data: New York State Comptroller; Note: Excludes stock options and other deferred compensation; Chart: Axios Visuals

The average annual bonus on Wall Street last year was \$246,900, up 6% from 2024, according to data out Thursday morning from the New York state comptroller's office.

Why it matters: Higher bonuses are a sign that finance had a good year — the market turmoil and uncertainty caused by the Trump administration's tariffs only helped boost business across Wall Street trading desks.

Zoom in: Profits in the securities industry rose more than 30%, to \$65.1 billion, according to the report from New York State Comptroller Thomas DiNapoli.

Wall Street's securities bonus pool was a record \$49.2 billion last year, up 9% from 2024.

The report estimates bonuses using income tax withholding data, looking at pay to securities industry employees working in New York City from December through March. It does not include stock options or other deferred compensation.

Reality check: When adjusted for inflation, the bonus pool actually peaked in 2006, at \$53.7 billion, the comptroller's report notes.

And last year's bonuses, adjusted for inflation, are still lower than during 2020 and 2021, when markets and

dealmaking boomed in the pandemic.

What they're saying: "Wall Street saw strong performance for much of last year, despite all of the ongoing domestic and international upheavals," DiNapoli said in a press release.

"When Wall Street does well, it's good for our state and city budgets, which are reliant on the industry's significant tax contributions."

What to watch: He also warned that slowing job growth and "geopolitical conflict" now pose risks for the financial sector and the economy.

Trump tells Iran to "get serious" in negotiations "before it is too late"

Barak Ravid · Axios

President Trump on Thursday called on the Iranian regime "to get serious soon" in negotiations with the U. S. "before it is too late."

Why it matters: The Trump administration through a group of mediators — Pakistan, Egypt and Turkey — has asked Iran to hold a high-level meeting this week to discuss a U. S. proposal for ending the war.

Trump's five-day pause on strikes against Iranian energy infrastructure expires Saturday, and a dramatic military escalation will grow more likely if no progress is made in diplomatic talks, particularly if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed.

Some U. S. officials think a crushing show of force to conclude the fighting would create more leverage in peace talks or simply give Trump something to point to and declare victory.

The Pentagon is developing military options for a "final blow" in Iran that could include ground forces and a massive bombing campaign, Axios reported.

Driving the news: Iranian state media reported Wednesday that Tehran rejected Trump's 15-point plan to end the war.

A senior Iranian official told Iran's English-language Press TV the U. S. terms were "excessive," called the negotiations "a ploy," and said the war would only end "on Tehran's own terms and timeline."

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt played down Iran's public posturing and said talks remain "productive."

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Iranian state TV on Wednesday that Iran is not negotiating with the U. S. and stressed messages are being delivered through third countries.

He claimed the U. S. proposal is being reviewed by Iran's top leadership.

What he's saying: "The Iranian negotiators are very different and strange. They are begging us to make a deal, which they should be doing since they have been militarily obliterated, with zero chance of a comeback, and yet they publicly state that they are only looking at our proposal. WRONG!!!" Trump wrote on Truth Social.

"They better get serious soon, before it is too late, because once that happens, there is NO TURNING BACK, and it won't be pretty!" he added.

What to watch: A source involved in the efforts to launch negotiations between the U. S. and Iran said Pakistan, Egypt and Turkey are still trying to organize a meeting between the parties.

The source said that while Iran rejected the initial U. S. demands, it did not rule out negotiations altogether.

"But mistrust is the problem. The commanders of the IRGC are very skeptical," the source said, referring to the powerful Iranian military force. "But the me-

Late night Senate vote puts DHS shutdown one step closer to largely ending

Andrew Solender · Axios

The U. S. Senate voted overnight to pass a bill that would reopen all of the Department of Homeland Security, except a few immigration enforcement agencies.

Why it matters: The vote puts Congress one step closer to ending a 42-day shutdown that has resulted in widespread airport security disruptions and missed paychecks for hundreds of thousands of workers at key national security agencies.

The breakthrough came after President Trump announced Thursday he planned to sign an order directing newly confirmed DHS Secretary Markwayne Mullin to begin paying TSA workers, sidestepping Congress.

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-S. D.) responded by telling Senate colleagues he still wanted to find a way to fund DHS through the traditional appropriations process rather than procedural workarounds.

What happened: Thune motioned early Friday morning to pass a bill that would fund most DHS sub-agencies, minus ICE and Customs and Border Protection, until September.

The bill passed unanimously, meaning none of the chamber's 53 Republicans or 47 Democrats objected.

The bill now heads to the House, where Democrats have notably been pushing

for a very similar step to the one Thune took.

Several House Democrats told Axios they plan to vote for the measure and expect their colleagues to do as well without much controversy.

"I think they have to vote yes," one House Dem said. "Want to go home. Airports a mess."

But the lack of funding for ICE and CBP may pose issues on the GOP side of things, according to multiple House Republicans, one of whom told Axios: "It's a problem."

What's next: If the bill passes, negotiations would focus in on ICE and CBP, which have been the subject of heated debate in recent months following the killings of several U. S. citizens during enforcement operations in Minnesota earlier this year.

The immigration enforcement agencies have remained open throughout the shutdown, however, thanks to roughly \$75 billion in additional funds provided through the One Big, Beautiful Bill Act.

Democrats have pushed hard for substantial reforms at the agencies, but Republicans and the Trump administration have thus far largely resisted giving in to their demands.

Editor's note: This story has been corrected to describe John Thune as the Senate majority (not minority) leader.

Judge questions Pentagon's "troubling" Anthropic actions

Maria Curi · Axios

A federal judge on Tuesday called the Pentagon's treatment of Anthropic "troubling" as the AI company urged the court to pause the Trump administration's designation of the company as a supply chain risk.

Why it matters: The Trump administration is looking to remove Claude from federal agencies and prevent companies that do business with the Pentagon from working with the AI lab.

Agencies have started to take action, and Anthropic says some companies are rethinking contracts.

What they're saying: "I don't know if it's murder, but it looks like an attempt to cripple Anthropic," said U. S. District Judge Rita Lin.

Lin referred to three Trump administration actions: President Trump's ban on Anthropic, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's requirement that Pentagon contractors cut commercial ties with the company, and Anthropic's designation as a supply chain risk.

"What is troubling to me about these three actions is that they don't really seem to be tailored to the stated national security concern. If the worry is about the integrity of the operational chain of command, [the Pentagon] could just stop using Claude," she said.

Driving the news: Anthropic is seeking to pause the designation, block its enforcement by federal agencies, and roll back actions already taken.

Anthropic argues that the court should restore the status quo from before the designation occurred, while the case — including First Amendment and procurement law claims — is litigated.

The company says that would help ease ongoing reputational damage and provide commercial partners more certainty.

Friction point: Essentially, the company argues, there should be a return to the status quo as of Feb. 26, before Trump and Hegseth said on social media that Anthropic would "immediately" be blacklisted.

The Pentagon's lawyer argued that the social media posts are not legally binding.

The judge said she found that argument "pretty surprising ... obviously the statement is front and center in this lawsuit."

The Pentagon argues in court filings that Anthropic has asked for an "operational veto" of the Pentagon's decision-making and that Anthropic has full control over Claude's availability and performance.

Department officials say that would be inappropriate and dangerous in sensitive operations.

Anthropic denies it has operational control over the model once deployed in classified settings.

“He needs to go”: Fetterman’s fellow Democrats rage over his vote on Mullin for DHS

Andrew Solender · Axios

Sen. John Fetterman (D-Pa.) is under heavy fire from fellow Democrats for casting the deciding vote to advance Sen. Markwayne Mullin’s (R-Okla.) nomination for DHS secretary, with some openly calling for his ouster.

Why it matters: The idea of trying to unseat Fetterman is never far from many Democrats’ minds, but rarely has it been discussed so explicitly and so openly.

“Once again Sen Fetterman shows why he is Trump’s favorite Democrat. He needs to go,” Rep. Brendan Boyle (D-Pa.), one of Fetterman’s harshest critics, said in a post on X.

Boyle, the top Democrat on the House Budget Committee and a rumored potential primary rival to Fetterman, has publicly criticized the senator before, but this was the first time he has expressed support for his removal.

Fetterman’s office did not respond to a request for comment on this story.

What happened: Fetterman voted with Republicans on the Senate Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs Committee to advance Mullin’s nomination to a floor vote.

The vote was 8-7, with all Democrats and Sen. Rand Paul (R-Ky.), the chair of the committee, voting against Mullin’s nomination — making Fetterman the deciding vote.

The Pennsylvania Democrat, first elected in 2022 as a progressive, has since stunned erstwhile allies by tacking to the right, staunchly defending Israel and extending frequent olive branches to the GOP.

What they’re saying: “If you needed any more proof that Fetterman has completely abandoned his constituents, here it is. Pennsylvanians deserve a Senator that actually fights for them,” Rep. Pat Ryan (D-N. Y.) said on X.

Rep. Chrissy Houlahan (D-Pa.), who had urged constituents ahead of the vote to call Fetterman’s office and ask him to oppose Mullin’s nomination, compared him negatively to Sen. Dave McCormick (R-Pa.) at a town hall Thursday night.

“Well, we have this senator — we have two actually,” she said to boos from the crowd. “And I have to be really honest with you, of the two I have more success in working with the one on the [Republican] side of the aisle than the one on the [Democratic] side of the aisle.”

Zoom out: It wasn’t just sitting members of Congress tearing into the Pennsylvania senator.

Former Rep. Conor Lamb, who was Fetterman’s top Democratic primary opponent in 2022 and has remained critical of him, posted on X: “Did people think this vigilante was voting to protect their rights? Come on.”

Moe Davis, an unsuccessful 2020 North Carolina congressional candidate, even apologized to former donors for sharing his donor list with the Fetterman campaign.

“I sincerely regret whatever part I had in helping to elect [John Fetterman] in 2022.”

The other side: “In January, I called on the president to fire [former DHS Secretary Kristi] Noem — and he did,” Fetterman said in a statement defending his vote.

“I truly approached the confirmation of my colleague and friend, Senator Mullin, with an open-mind. We need a leader at DHS. We must reopen DHS.”

Fetterman said his vote was “rooted in a strong committed, constructive working relationship with Senator Mullin for our nation’s security.”

), who had urged constituents ahead of the vote to call Fetterman's office and ask him to oppose Mullin's nomination, compared him negatively to Sen.

Andrew Solender

SCOTUS set to deal major blow to mail voting ahead of midterms

Jelinda Montes · Salon

In the 2024 election, nearly one in three Americans voted using mail-in or absentee ballots, accounting for some 48 million votes. And despite persistent rhetoric against it, even President Donald Trump votes by mail. Nevertheless, Trump further admonished mail voting while pushing the SAVE America Act, which could radically change how people vote ahead of the midterms. “Mail-in voting means mail-in cheating,” he said to press in Memphis, Tenn., Monday. “I call it mail-in cheating, and we got to do something about it all.”

Outside of the legislature, another body is doing something about mail ballots that may change how millions of Americans vote. The U. S. Supreme Court began oral arguments Monday on *Watson v. RNC*, a case determining if Mississippi allowing late mail-in ballots violates federal law establishing a specific election day. The largest question in this case is whether ballots need to be received by Election Day or just be cast by Election Day and allowed to be received later.

“I don’t think it’s a coincidence that you’re seeing the Trump administration talk about mail-in ballots in the SAVE Act at the same time that that case is going to be heard by the Supreme Court,” Travis Crum, an election law professor at the Washington University in St. Louis, said.

The conservative woman cracking down on conservative women

The Supreme Court seems poised to reject the Mississippi law based on oral arguments where justices were particularly incisive about the potential to recall a ballot and concerns of perceived fraud.

Washington, D. C. and 13 other states have similar laws to Mississippi in which ballots postmarked on or before Election Day will be counted within a certain period of time after Election Day. In Mississippi’s case, ballots can be received within five business days after the election so long as they’re sent by Election Day.

The Republican National Convention challenged this law in Mississippi, arguing it violates the 1845 Presidential Election Day Act that established a single election day as the Tuesday after the first Monday in November. They posit that Congress choosing one specific election day overrides a state’s ability to accept ballots afterward, even if they’re postmarked by Election Day.

“One of the interesting things here is we are debating the meaning of a law that was passed 180 years ago,” Michael Morley, the director of the Florida State University’s Election Law Center, said in an interview with Salon.

“I think it’s pretty hard to argue that all of the election was happening on Election Day.”

Morley, who filed a friend of the court brief in this case for neither party, argues that, in the modern day, no one reads the Presidential Election Day act literally. The law says Election Day is when each state shall appoint their electors for president and vice president, which is no longer done on actual Election Day due to the amount of time it takes to process and organize ballots and electors.

“I think it’s pretty hard to argue that all of the election was happening on Election Day,” Morley said. He believes the Supreme Court needs to resolve the “vagueness and ambiguity” of the Election Day laws and possibly remand it back to a lower court before it can make a decision regarding the Mississippi late ballots law.

Others say history and the text are clear in demonstrating that Mississippi doesn’t violate federal law. Throughout this nearly two century period, Congress has not acted to prevent states from accepting Election Day postmarked ballots in the days following the election.

“There’s just no question that Congress has always been aware of the variability in state ballot laws and has never acted to disrupt that,” Anna Baldwin, the Campaign Legal Center’s director of voting rights litigation, told Salon. Campaign Legal Center also filed a friend of the court brief in the case, this time in support of Mississippi.

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“If Congress had wanted to make a change, where you would’ve expected them to say something about that, it would have been in Electoral Account Reform Act,” Baldwin said. “The fact that they didn’t just is even more evidence that they intended to maintain the status quo.”

The Electoral Count Act of 2022 updated the 1887 Electoral Count Act, making clarifications around ambiguous language on the casting and counting of electoral votes. The law did not prohibit state statutes around ballot receipt deadlines. Another law, the 1986 Uniformed and Overseas Citizens Absentee Voting Act, allows for military and abroad citizens to vote. Twenty-nine states allow those absentee ballots to be postmarked and received after Election Day, and it is unclear if the case against Mississippi will affect these state laws and abroad voters.

“The Supreme Court shouldn’t be considering those kinds of policy considerations in making its determination.”

Throughout the oral arguments, various justices brought up concerns about the potential for absentee voters to recall their ballots to change or alter them in some type of way. Common delivery services like UPS or FedEx typically allow users to recall mail they sent and have it returned to them. Baldwin argues claims around the possibility of recall are outlandish, but also something that the court shouldn’t be addressing.

“Mail voting law plays an important role for a number of constituencies, including military and overseas voters, and

What to know about Iran's military as the U.S. weighs ground operations

Avery Lotz · Axios

Iran's military has taken a significant beating in the opening weeks of the U. S.-Israeli offensive — but Tehran continues to demonstrate a defiant disruptiveness.

The big picture: The U. S. is developing military operations for a “final blow,” Axios’ Barak Ravid reported, but some hypothetical next steps, like the use of ground forces, could risk intensifying the fight.

Context: Trump has repeatedly claimed that the war is essentially over, but Iran continues to launch strikes against Israel and other Gulf countries. The nation is also maintaining the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, impacting oil and gas prices worldwide.

The White House and the Pentagon are considering sending at least 10,000 additional combat troops to the Middle East in the coming days, a senior U. S. defense official told Axios.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) ground forces number more than 150,000 troops, per the Council on Foreign Relations, on top of the Basij paramilitary force and Iran's larger conventional Army.

Read on for more on what's known about the state of Iran's military:

Israel said its opening strikes took out seven senior defense and intelligence officials and targeted 30 top military and civilian leaders, including Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) Cmdr. Mohammad Pakpour .

Several IRGC leaders have since been killed , and on Thursday, Israel said it had killed Iranian Navy Cmdr. Alireza Tangsiri.

It's left behind what Behnam Ben Taleblu, Foundation for Defense of Democracies' Iran Program senior director, described as a “zombie regime.”

Missiles and drones

U. S. officials have repeatedly touted Iran's plummeting missile and drone attack volume and the number of U. S. strikes on military targets, which have hit 10,000.

But Kelly Grieco, a senior fellow at the Stimson Center, says those two metrics are “problematic,” emphasizing that launch rates are a hazy metric to demonstrate diminished capability.

The fall could signal that the U. S. and Israel have successfully constrained Iran's ability to hit back, but “the problem is, it's not the only hypothesis,” she says.

“If it's not that we've destroyed capability, capacity ... it means that they have more in reserve, which means that at some point they could decide to use that,” she said.

What they're saying: A Department of Defense official said in a statement provided to Axios that “Iranian missile and air defense systems are heavily degraded” and added that CENTCOM has “damaged or destroyed over 66% of Iranian missile, drone, and naval production facilities and shipyards.”

Israel says it has destroyed or disabled 330 of Iran's estimated 470 ballistic missile launchers. But Iranian responses have persisted.

A recent report from the Jewish Institute for National Security of America found that while U. S., Israeli and Arab air defenses have intercepted over 90% of Iranian missiles and drones, Iranian strikes on radar systems have eroded the detection network.

Threat level: Iran's Shahed drones are cheap and easy to produce, as well as harder to “detect and defeat than its missiles, and produced more than double the hits,” per JINSA.

Open-source estimates on Iran's capacity of those drones vary widely, Grieco says, adding “it's really hard to be able to track” the amount they've built as production can be decentralized.

Air and ground forces

U. S. intelligence assessed last year that Iran's ground and air forces were among the largest in the region but had limited training and outdated equipment.

Notably, the war could signal Iranian F-14s' final days, per NPR . The U. S. sold the crafts to the Iranians in the 1970s before the Islamic Revolution.

As the Trump administration weighs a potential ground attack on Kharg Island, CNN reports from sources familiar that the Iranians are moving additional military personnel and air defenses to the island.

U. S. forces could be vulnerable to a range of missile and drone threats if a ground escalation ensued, given the island's proximity to the mainland.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth says that more than 150 Iranian Navy vessels have been sunk since military strikes began in late February.

U. S. forces have targeted Iranian minelaying vessels, with CENTCOM saying 16 were taken out near the Strait of Hormuz on March 10.

Reality check: While the U. S. and Israel have pummeled Iranian naval vessels and known ballistic missile sites, it would be impossible to fully wipe out Iran's military capacity from the sky.

Iran uses hundreds of smaller speed boats to harass larger ships in the Gulf, and has networks of underground bunkers on land that have likely survived the bombing campaign.

“The Forsyte Saga” is about hot men and the money they love

Melanie McFarland · Salon

What is a Forsyte? Lots of people may ask this question as excitement or dread builds around the PBS debut of “The Forsytes.” That excitement is because it is one of those titles that quietly shaped every period drama and miniseries that came after it.

The dread comes from fears of a reinterpretation of John Galsworthy’s Nobel Prize-winning books, collectively known as “The Forsyte Saga,” to suit an audience besotted with “Bridgerton” and other sensual period adaptations. Still, most who try to define a Forsyte do so because they aren’t familiar with these stories. At least, not in book form.

That benign ignorance will serve PBS’ highly liberal adaptation of the series very well.

“The Forsytes” is inspired by Galsworthy’s family of extremely wealthy stockbrokers in late-Victorian London, an age in which nobility’s influence and social dominance receded with the rise of new money. Nominally headed by its matriarch, Ann Forsyte (Francesca Annis), the series looks at how the overwhelming expectations of the older generation, led by Ann’s two ornery middle-aged sons, bring strife on their offspring.

Watching “Bridgerton” in a “Heated Rivalry” world

Jolyon (Danny Griffin) is expected to assume leadership of the family firm, per tradition. But his uncle sees Jolyon as too soft to keep the firm competitive, believing his own son Soames (Joshua Orpin) to be a more suitably hard-nosed successor.

Sounds like “The Gilded Age,” right? That it does, which is why these books have been unearthed from the stacks yet again. “The Forsytes” is a clunky visual feast, but it’s also a new hot dish in an expanding buffet of eat-the-rich takes that materializes what one imagines a serialized adaptation of Gentlemen’s Quarterly would look like.

Galsworthy’s stories always had suds around the edges, but these new episodes are also a good deal hornier. Jolyon is played by a male model whose lustrous mane gets more of a workout than his emotional range. His character also boxes, preferring to spar shirtless.

Meanwhile, Orpin’s muscular flexing in Soames’ fitted T-shirts rivals anything Jeremy Allen White serves in “The Bear.” Even their rich daddies (played by Stephen Moyer and Jack Davenport) can still get it. Doubt me? Compare them to the grizzled, huffy statesmen who previously played those roles, especially in the 2002 ITV adaptation. Seriously, see for yourself — it’s currently streaming on Netflix. Unless you have a kink for Milburn Pennybags, aka the Monopoly man, my opinion stands.

(PBS) Joshua Orpin as Soames Forsyte and Danny Griffin as Jolyon Forsyte in “The Forsytes”

Debbie Horsfield, who made millions swoon with “Poldark” before taking on this adaptation for PBS, recognizes the place that “The Forsyte Saga” holds in TV history. Every miniseries and period piece that came after the 1967 adaptation looks and feels the way they do because of what that series achieved. It brought the bootstrapping fantasy of this rising family, a few generations removed from the toiling class, into Britain’s living rooms with the right blend of serious theatricality and soapy splendor.

But the sensibilities of corset-and-bustle dramas have vastly changed since the first “Forsyte Saga” enthralled 18 million U. K. viewers nearly 60 years ago. (Once the world got in on the phenomenon — including, in a historic first for the BBC, the Soviet Union — viewership swelled to an estimated 160 million.)

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From age to age, defining what makes a Forsyte has grown trickier. Galsworthy’s heroes represent the way new money can be trapped between stifling tradition and modern realities, but our social boundaries are constantly shifting. And while previous TV adaptations root into the emotional interiority of their male characters while sidelining female desire, “The Forsytes” places more narrative purpose in the hands of its women.

That idea starts with Ann Forsyte’s table-setting narration, a la Lady Whistledown in “Bridgerton.” But it also plays out in the storyline between Jolyon, the favorite son, and Louisa Byrne (“Poldark” star Eleanor Tomlinson), a figure from his bohemian past. Once upon a time, he lived out his starving artist fantasies abroad before putting that aside to join the family business. He pretends to be content with all the trappings of wealth, but Louisa’s accidental reemergence makes him question everything — including his otherwise happy union with his carefully chosen wife (Tuppence Middleton), who understands the Forsytes’ ambition better than he does.

(PBS) Millie Gibson as Irene Heron and Joshua Orpin as Soames Forsyte in “The Forsytes”

While Jolyon is a central character in “The Forsytes,” Soames’ inner conflict is Galsworthy’s cynosure: He’s a man who prizes acquisition and possession to the extent that he cannot love. As he’s classically rendered, Soames verges on unpalatable.

That also makes him a challenge for any actor to take on. Errol Flynn’s rendition in 1949’s “That Forsyte Woman” is viewed as one of his best performances. Damian Lewis’ 2002 version, captured fresh off his career-making work in “Band of Brothers,” shivers with trussed-up desire gone spoiled and toxic. And yet, in the end, you can’t help but pity the man.

White House AI rollout exposes widening rift

Ashley Gold · Axios

A week after the White House unveiled its long-awaited national AI legislative framework, Washington has renewed momentum to pass federal laws but no roadmap on how to get there.

Why it matters: The administration's loose AI playbook for Congress is exposing cracks beneath the GOP's apparent consensus.

What they're saying: At the Axios AI+DC Summit this week, attendees grumbled about a lack of clarity in the copy-right section of the framework as Republican members of Congress showcased diverging opinions on AI's impact on voters and kids.

White House Office of Science and Technology Policy director Michael Kratsios struck a hopeful tone about Congress getting something done, even as disagreements about how far Congress should go threaten to stall progress.

When asked if the goal is to have Congress send a bill to the president's desk this year, he said: "Yes, we want to try to get it as expeditiously as possible."

Take, for instance, the different ways that Rep. Kat Cammack (R-Fla.) and Sen. Josh Hawley (R-Mo.) reacted to Meta and YouTube being found liable in a Los Angeles court for making their products addictive.

When asked if the ruling should influence how any AI bill treats kids' online safety, Cammack said that "I don't think that this is the bombshell that everyone thinks that it is."

Instead, she called it "more of a level-setter" as lawmakers try to reconcile the differences between the House and Senate approaches to kids' online safety.

Hawley, in contrast, called the verdict "hugely significant" and said it's time for Congress to take action to ban AI chatbots for minors.

"These juries just said no amount of profit justifies destroying a child's life," he said. "It'd be nice if the United States Congress maybe got on the same page."

Zoom in: Key sticking points include:

Kids' online safety: Republicans are split over whether to hold platforms liable for harms or pursue lighter-touch rules focused on transparency and parental controls.

Copyright: They're divided over how to protect creators as AI firms train on copyrighted material, and the White House wants to leave it up to the courts.

Data centers: They're searching for a path forward as they face growing local backlash over energy and land use as the

White House calls on Congress to shield households from higher power bills.

Friction point: It's possible Republicans lose some political control after the midterms, but Democrats have their own divides.

Sen. Mark Warner (D-Va.) at the summit called a proposal from Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-N. Y.) to pass a moratorium on building AI data centers "idiocy."

What we're watching: Some Democrats are trying to sharpen the party's AI message, including Rep. Josh Gottheimer (D-N. J.), who co-chairs the House Democratic Commission on AI.

"Our job is to put together the Democratic perspective on AI in the House of Representatives and the legislative agenda," he said at an event hosted by SeedAI in Washington this week.

"I'm hoping we win the House in a few months and we'll be governing next year. And so it's very important that we have put forward a clear perspective and a legislative agenda."

Meta and YouTube found negligent in landmark social media addiction trial

Ashley Gold · Axios

A jury on Wednesday found Big Tech giants Meta and YouTube negligent in a landmark social media trial, awarding \$3 million in compensation to a woman who argued the companies were to blame for her social media addiction.

Why it matters: It is rare that social media giants are found liable for any harms people may face using their platforms, and the verdict in the Los Angeles trial could lead to more court losses, more lawsuits and potentially online safety legislation.

What they're saying: "This verdict sends an unmistakable message that no company is above accountability when it comes to our children," the plaintiffs' counsel said in a statement.

"Top tech executives took the stand, and their own internal documents were put before a jury, revealing that company leadership knew their platforms were hurting kids and repeatedly chose profits over children's safety," they said.

A Meta spokesperson said that "we will continue to defend ourselves vigorously as every case is different, and we remain confident in our record of protecting teens online."

The jury also later recommended an additional \$3 million in punitive damages.

Catch up quick: Meta and Google's YouTube were the remaining defendants in the bellwether case, which involved a woman from California identified in court documents as K. G. M.

K. G. M., also known as Kaley, started using YouTube when she was six and Instagram around age nine. She said that social media addiction led to depression, anxiety and body dysmorphia.

TikTok and Snap previously settled .

The plaintiffs' core argument was that social media is a product that should be held to product liability standards, not a platform where Section 230 shields company executives from liability for design choices.

The verdict comes one day after a jury in New Mexico ordered Meta to pay \$375 million over harms to young users.

Flashback: Zuckerberg testified earlier this year, with lawyers grilling him over past statements about his company's role in child safety and knowledge of alleged harms.

This was the first time Zuckerberg had faced a jury in a courtroom alongside families who said that Meta's products harmed their children .

Meta president Dina Powell McCormick said Wednesday at Axios' AI+DC Summit that "we respectfully disagree with that decision and we're appealing."

"But I think back to people, not products — it's something that probably consumes the leadership's time in a massive percentage every single day."

"It's something that we're going to keep working hard [on], and try to protect young people on our platform," she added.

Our thought bubble: For the majority of the social media era, companies shook off accusations of neglect from those who argued their lack of safeguards cause harm to users of all ages.

Now, there's court precedent showing that argument may no longer fly, just as AI changes how people use social media in new and sometimes dangerous ways.

What we're watching: Another bellwether social media trial, which is set to begin in June in federal court, puts together nationwide cases from attorneys general, school districts, local governments and families.

Editor's note: This story was updated to include Dina Powell McCormick's and Meta's comments.

Trump's team game planning for potential Iran peace talks

Barak Ravid · Axios

After three weeks of war, the Trump administration has begun initial discussions on the next phase and what peace talks with Iran might look like, according to a U. S. official and a source with knowledge.

Why it matters: President Trump said Friday that he was considering “winding down” the war, though U. S. officials said the expectation was there would still be two to three additional weeks of fighting. In the meantime, Trump’s advisers want to start laying groundwork for diplomacy.

Behind the scenes: Trump’s envoys Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff are involved in the discussions around potential diplomacy, sources say.

Any deal to end the war would need to include the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, address Iran’s stockpile of highly enriched uranium, and also establish a long-term agreement on Iran’s nuclear program, ballistic missiles and support for proxies in the region.

There has been no direct contact between the U. S. and Iran in recent days, though Egypt, Qatar and the U. K. have all passed messages between the two, a U. S. official and two additional sources with knowledge said. Egypt and Qatar have informed the U. S. and Israel that Iran is interested in negotiating, but with very tough terms.

The Iranian demands include a ceasefire, guarantees that the war will not resume in the future, and compensation.

Between the lines: “Our view is we’ve stunted Iran’s growth,” said one U. S. official who believes the Iranians will come to the table. The official said the U. S. wants Iran to make six commitments:

No missile program for five years.

Zero uranium enrichment.

Decommissioning the Natanz, Isfahan and Fordow nuclear facilities that the U. S. and Israel bombed last year.

Strict outside observation protocols around the creation and use of centrifuges and related machinery that could advance a nuclear weapons program.

Arms control treaties with regional countries that include a missile cap no higher than 1,000.

No financing for proxies such as Hezbollah in Lebanon, the Houthis in Yemen or Hamas in Gaza.

Reality check: Iran has repeatedly rejected several of those demands in the past, and leaders in Tehran have noted the difficulty of negotiating with a president who has engaged in talks in the past only to suddenly bomb them.

Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told his Indian counterpart on Saturday that normalizing the situation in the Strait of Hormuz would require the U. S. and Israel to stop attacking Iran and commit not to resume the attacks in future, the Iranian foreign ministry said.

As for Trump, he said Friday that he does not oppose talks, but is not interested at the moment in meeting Iran’s demands for a ceasefire.

Trump also sees the demand for reparations as a “non-starter,” a U. S. official said.

Between the lines : A second official said there could be room to negotiate over returning frozen assets to Iran.

“They call it reparations. Maybe we call it return of frozen money. There’s many different ways that we can wordsmith so that it solves politically what they need to solve, to develop consensus in their system,” the official said.

“That’s wordsmithing. We have to first get to the place of having the high-quality problem of wordsmithing.”

State of play: Trump’s team is currently trying to answer two key questions: Who in Iran is the best point of contact for negotiations, and which country is best mediator?

Araghchi has been the primary intermediary in past talks, but Trump advisers see him as a “fax machine” rather than someone who is empowered to actually deliver a deal, U. S. officials say.

They’re trying to figure out who actually makes decisions in Iran and how to get in touch with them, U. S. officials say.

And while Oman mediated the last round of nuclear talks, the U. S. is seeking a different mediator, ideally Qatar, due to mutual distrust with the Omanis. U. S. officials said the Qataris proved themselves to be effective and trusted mediators in Gaza.

The Qataris are willing the help behind the scenes, but don’t want to be the main official mediators, two sources said.

What’s next: The sources said Trump’s advisers want to be prepared if talks with Iran take shape in the near future.

Witkoff and Kushner’s terms will be similar to the ones they presented in Geneva two days before the war started, according to the sources.

Go deeper: CIA searches for signs of Iran’s new leader

The New Forever War in Iran Keeps the Dog Wagging

Katherine Mangu-Ward · Reason

At press time, the U. S. is engaged in a war with Iran—or at least very warlike behavior, including taking out much of a sitting government, killing Iran’s supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several top military commanders, dropping 2,000-pound bombs from B-2 stealth bombers on missile and nuclear facilities, and launching Tomahawk cruise missiles and drones at hundreds of targets across the country.

Why? That depends on whom you ask and on which day. Perhaps there was an imminent threat—maybe even a nuclear threat?—to the United States. Or perhaps the Iranian regime is a sponsor of terror, on which we have already declared war. Or perhaps we need to support our allies in the region. Or perhaps just because Khamenei was just a world-historically murderous bastard, even in a region famed for its murderous bastards.

Here’s a good rule of thumb, both for understanding foreign policy and also for life in general: When someone offers a bunch of rapid-fire and mutually irreconcilable justifications for a controversial decision, they’re not telling you the whole story.

William Shakespeare might have invoked letting slip the dogs of war to describe the unleashing of violence, but these days we just “wag the dog.” Popularized by *Our American Cousin*—the play being performed at Ford’s Theatre when President Abraham Lincoln was shot—the phrase took on an explicitly political meaning after the ripped-from-the-headlines 1997 film *Wag the Dog*. In that otherwise pretty awful movie, a fabricated military conflict was used to distract voters from a presidential sex scandal. Since then, the term has become shorthand for the idea that leaders sometimes use military action to divert attention from problems at home.

A wag-the-dog allegation need not mean the reasons for war are made up from whole cloth. Real geopolitical tensions, real strategic dilemmas, and real threats obviously exist. But the utility of a foreign conflict as a tool for domestic political positioning—especially when electoral outcomes are looking shaky—is a recurring theme in American history.

Trump’s approval ratings are notably terrible. National polling aggregates suggest his job approval stands somewhere near 40 percent. A president facing a highly competitive election year and significant scrutiny on issues ranging from the economy to the ongoing incredulity and disappointment about the release of the Epstein files might well cast about for a distraction.

The war also doesn’t necessarily have to be popular to accomplish some doggy goals. Though reporting suggests that President Donald Trump believed Americans in general, and his MAGA supporters more specifically, would rally around the war, a Reuters/Ipsos survey shows only

about 27 percent of the country approving of the strikes on Iran, while 43 percent disapprove and many are uncertain. A larger poll conducted by the University of Maryland before the attacks suggested that even fewer Americans support a U. S. attack on Iran under current circumstances, as low as around 21 percent.

The two Trump terms have dramatically shortened the public’s attention span. After a strike on Iran in June, which the administration declared a total success in eliminating Iran’s nuclear capability, the president might have hoped for a polling bump, some “strange new respect” from the more hawkish Republicans on the Hill, or at least a few more days of coverage. But that episode quickly faded from view (and didn’t resolve any of the underlying problems in the region). But Americans didn’t seem to hate it either. So the temptation emerged to try again.

Even when wars are unpopular or divisive, they command attention and can reframe political discourse away from domestic grievances and toward questions of national security. A war does not need majority support to serve this function. It needs only to be salient enough to shift the conversation.

Even days of online dunking and pushback on Trump’s inconsistencies on war with Iran can have a kind of invigorating effect. And at least the topic has some gravitas, unlike the slow-moving Epstein disaster or the dismal economic data constantly trickling out.

Trump ran as an opponent of “forever wars,” and he won over at least some voters with that emphasis. Those voters—and perhaps more importantly, increasingly fractious GOP influencers such as Tucker Carlson and Megyn Kelly—are justifiably angry. Democratic politicians and voters are, of course, more than happy to pick holes in the confused and confusing justifications for a war launched without respect for Congress or the opinions of the American people.

Too little, too late, Congress has creaked into slow action to hint at protecting its privileges to wage war. Once military action begins, it becomes easier for leaders to justify extensions, surges, and escalations without ever obtaining the degree of popular backing that a war with clear goals—or a thoughtful peace—might command.

The current conflict with Iran, unlike the fictional war in *Wag the Dog*, is rooted in decades of geopolitical friction, sanctions, proxy battles, and strategic competition. Many Iranians, at least in these early days, have reacted with joy to American bombings. But it remains true that when foreign policy is conducted in the service of domestic politics, wars become tempting as tools of distraction, puffery, and electoral signaling.

Perhaps the many competing explanations offered for this war each capture some part of the truth. But when the list grows long and the emphasis keeps shifting, that often means the conflict is doing more than one job. And wars that do multiple jobs for the people waging them—military,

Even when wars are unpopular or divisive, they command attention and can reframe political discourse away from domestic grievances and toward questions of national security.

Katherine Mangu-Ward

I Spent Over 3 Hours in a TSA Line. Why Haven't We Abolished This Agency?

Billy Binion · Reason

I am not one to get to the airport early. Why would I? I take no joy in sitting in a terminal. I do not need to eat at Chili's. I will not join the Group 5 passengers who preemptively crowd around the boarding door like they're waiting for the last chopper out of Saigon. And I am not opposed to an airport sprint (I could probably use the cardio), though it rarely gets to that point. I have never missed a flight.

So imagine my dismay when the closest I came to doing so, if memory serves, was when I arrived at the airport three hours and 40 minutes prior to takeoff on Sunday.

My flight home from a wedding in New Orleans coincided with the 37th day of the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) shutdown, which, among other things, has seen agents with the Transportation Security Administration (TSA) go unpaid. Hundreds have resigned. Several airports, including New Orleans, have experienced sky-high call-out rates. On Sunday, 42.3 percent of TSA officers there called out of work, per numbers provided by the federal government.

The result was more disastrous than I could have imagined. Upon entering the airport, the security line spilled down from the second floor into the lobby, where I got in line. Except that was not the end of the line. It was a break in the line, which had fractured as people filed in from the parking garage, where the line actually ended. So to the garage I went. Finding the end point was another thing entirely. Passengers were instructed that they would know they had reached their destination when they saw, hilariously, a red flag. Around and around we walked in the concrete maze, flanked by people on both sides, who were somehow standing in the same line. Which side was ahead? Which was behind? Who can say?

The prize for finally making it to that red flag: a three-hour, 20-minute TSA wait, which consisted of about two hours in the garage, an hour and change inside, anxious phone-checking on a dying device, a pair of travelers concocting a business idea for a TSA-line beverage service with very high market prices we were all willing to pay, a woman doing yoga, travelers asking to cut in front because their flight was boarding (which, um, hello), and a fire alarm going off that we all just sort of ignored.

Also present in the air around us was (shockingly) a lot of frustration. Abolishing the TSA is often viewed as a kooky pipe dream. But I have never seen such a clear, obvious case for doing just that than the TSA line in New Orleans, which existed only because the functionality of airport security currently depends on whether Congress can agree on a budget. People will bicker over whether the fault lies with Republicans or Democrats. Beyond debate, however, is that scores of people have been inconvenienced or had their lives temporarily upended because federal lawmakers could not reach consensus on what is arguably the most

basic part of their job: approving spending bills. The ability to get home should not be a privilege contingent on the political moment.

There are, of course, objections beyond this, including that the TSA isn't very good at what it does. A DHS investigation in 2015 found that undercover operatives successfully got mock explosives or banned weapons through airport security 95 percent of the time. "Experts have long emphasized that the TSA is geared towards assuring the public that Something Very Important is being done to keep people safe, even as money and energy is squandered on pointless activities and useless devices," wrote Reason Contributing Editor J. D. Tuccille in 2022. Consider that travelers were recently permitted to go through TSA lines with their shoes on after years of having to remove them. The world kept spinning, and the planes kept flying. One security measure taken after 9/11 was very important: Cockpit doors now lock, so no longer is it possible for a wannabe hijacker to break in with a box cutter, a change more consequential than the creation of an entire agency.

But more to the point of the current fiasco, also consider that several airports across the U. S. have largely privatized security. That includes San Francisco, a major hub that has not missed potential terror attacks and is currently not drowning in call-outs and lengthy lines. Those private contractors are still subject to regulations, but their ability to fund operations does not hinge on the whims of politicians. Commercial airports in Canada and most of Europe also use private screeners.

What is the argument against this? "If I was a traveling passenger, I would be so much happier to know that these TSA officers are career dedicated civil servants to have nothing else to do but to make sure that I get to where I'm supposed to be safely," Johnny Jones, secretary treasurer for the American Federation of Government Employees, told San Francisco's ABC affiliate.

I cannot speak for everyone. But my happiness at the airport hinges purely on whether I get to my destination safely and on time. After arriving at the New Orleans airport before 2 p.m., I found myself sprinting to the gate (hello, old friend) at 5:20 p.m., hoping to make it before the gate closed imminently. The gate agent appeared skeptical that I still had a seat, I assume because they were in the process of reassigning no-shows to those who had missed previous flights for the same reason I was about to miss mine. I was not happy about the situation, nor, I imagine, were the passengers who missed what was the last American Airlines flight to D. C. that evening. Had we been in San Francisco, that would not have been the case.

The post I Spent Over 3 Hours in a TSA Line. Why Haven't We Abolished This Agency? appeared first on Reason.com .

Scoop: Rubio and EU official had heated exchange on Russia at G7 meeting

Barak Ravid · Axios

EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas asked Secretary of State Marco Rubio when the U. S. would get tough on Russia during a G7 ministers meeting on Friday, sparking a sharp retort, according to three sources who attended the meeting.

Why it matters: The tense exchange, which took place in front of allied foreign ministers, was symptomatic of the mutual distrust between the U. S. and many of its European allies over the war in Ukraine .

Behind the scenes: During a discussion of Ukraine, Kallas — a Russia hawk and former prime minister of Estonia — criticized the U. S. for not increasing pressure on Moscow, according to the sources.

She noted that Rubio had said at the same forum a year earlier that if Russia hampered U. S. efforts to end the war, the U. S. would run out of patience and take more steps against the Kremlin.

“A year has passed and Russia hasn’t moved,” Kallas told Rubio, according to the sources. “When is your patience going to run out?”

The other side: Rubio was visibly annoyed, according to the sources.

“We are doing the best we can to end the war. If you think you can do it better, go ahead. We will step aside,” he fired back, raising his voice.

Rubio said the U. S. was trying to talk to both sides, but

was only helping one side, Ukraine, with weapons, intelligence and other support.

After that heated exchange, several European ministers in the room interjected to say they still wanted the U. S. to pursue Russia-Ukraine diplomacy, one source said.

Two sources said that at the end of the meeting, Rubio and Kallas had a short pull-aside to try and cool down things.

What they’re saying: “It was a frank exchange of views. This is what diplomacy is for,” a State Department official told Axios.

A spokesperson for Kallas declined to comment.

In a gaggle with reporters after the G7 meeting, Rubio denied there had been any tensions or criticism.

“These meetings are oftentimes about thanking America for the role we played... and appreciation for the mediating role we’ve tried to play in this war between Russia and Ukraine,” Rubio said. No one there screams or raises their voices or says anything negative.“

Zoom out: European leaders have been nervous about the U. S.-led peace talks between Ukraine and Russia for months.

The war in Iran increased the anxiety in Europe, especially after the U. S. gave waivers to allow the sale of Russian oil, now at ever-higher prices.

Last weekend, a senior Ukrainian delegation visited Miami and

No Kings Rallygoers in New York Share Their Biggest Fears—and Greatest Hopes

James West · Mother Jones

I’ve covered all the No Kings protests in New York City since the start of Trump’s second presidency. What has struck me about all of them is how they fuse people’s fears with their hopes. The fear is what drives people onto the streets: threats to democracy, the war in Iran, attacks on LGBTQ Americans. The hope: each other, the promise of change. So, amid a raucous sea of angry, festive rallygoers along Manhattan’s 7th Avenue on Saturday, I asked people: What is your biggest fear and greatest hope right now?

“I’m here because they’re fucking building concentration camps that they’re locking tens of thousands of people in, and ICE is in our fucking airports,” the artist (and “Mother Jones fan”) Molly Crabapple told me. “Too many people are dying and too many people are in cages.” And while she doesn’t typically think “in hope,” she was inspired by the community. “I know we have each other and I don’t know if that’s enough, but that’s all we have.”

For Matthew Nichols, a 56-year-old arts worker, the greatest fear is November’s midterms—that “there’ll be some significant interference,” he said. “All of these things that seemed far-fetched maybe a year ago or two years ago are actually coming to pass.”

Ash, 29, a Mexican agricultural worker, says he fears people being silenced and “losing empathy” but, like others I met, pointed to “all

of us,” gesturing around, as providing him with hope. “People from all walks of life. Rich people, poor people, white people, black people. Everyone. So, it’s quite powerful.”

What they're saying: "It was a frank exchange of views."

Barak Ravid

Oil prices rise as Iran war escalates with Houthi attacks

Chuck McCutcheon · Axios

Oil prices climbed above \$116 per barrel after markets opened Sunday, as Iran-backed Houthi militants fired missiles and drones at Israel over the weekend and promised to continue attacks.

Why it matters: The increase came as the war moved into its fifth week, showing little sign of abating despite President Trump's talk of diplomacy.

Driving the news: The global benchmark Brent crude rose 3.3% to \$116.25 per barrel.

WTI, the main U. S. reference, was also up about 3% to nearly \$103 per barrel.

The big picture: More than 3,500 U. S. troops, including about 2,500 Marines, arrived in the Middle East, officials said Saturday.

The speaker of Iran's parliament, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, threatened to set U. S. troops "on fire" and step up attacks on American allies, according to Iranian official media.

The Houthis claimed responsibility for a missile attack on Israel on Saturday, raising concerns about the rebel group entering the fighting.

Israel said it intercepted the missile from Yemen — the first time it has seen an attack from that country since the war began.

Friction point: Rep. Jim Himes (D-Conn.), the House Intelligence Committee's top Democrat,

accused Trump Sunday of "flat-out lying" about negotiating with Iran and said Trump has emboldened the Iranians.

"The Iranians have now realized they have the reins," Himes said on "CBS This Morning." "Gasoline prices are up more than \$1 a gallon. They have realized, 'Holy smokes, we've got a lot of leverage here.'"

Gasoline prices edged closer to the \$4-a-gallon mark on Sunday, rising from \$3.976 to \$3.98 a gallon, per AAA .

Energy historian Daniel Yergin , vice chairman of S&P Global, said Sunday he remains concerned that the Houthis will disrupt shipping lanes in the Red Sea, an alternative to the Strait of Hormuz.

The Iranians have blocked most oil traffic in the strait, which handles about one-fifth of the world's seaborne oil trade.

"If the Houthis step up their attacks, if they join their allies in really attacking shipping or scaring people away from the Red Sea, that will aggravate what is already the most severe oil disruption that we have seen in history," Yergin said on Fox News.

Yes, but: Eurasia Group analysts predicted in a Saturday note that payoffs from Saudi Arabia will likely prevent the Houthis from launching major attacks against that country's extensive oil infrastructure.

But Eurasia Group said "the probable escalation of the war against Iran will push the Houthis to take some

House says "No deal!" as long lines at TSA continue to grow

CK Smith · Salon

A Senate deal to reopen most of the Department of Homeland Security didn't even last a day.

Early Friday, senators approved a plan to fund DHS — deliberately excluding Immigration and Customs Enforcement — in what lawmakers framed as a temporary off-ramp to end the weeks-long shutdown. Within hours, House Republicans rejected it outright, refusing to consider any bill that didn't fully fund immigration enforcement and instead pushing their own competing proposal.

The result: a stalemate that has now stretched well past a month, with Congress effectively at an impasse and little sign of a near-term resolution.

The consequences are no longer abstract. They're unfolding at airport security checkpoints across the country.

After working without pay and facing the prospect of missing a second paycheck, Transportation Security Administration agents have been calling out sick or quitting in growing numbers. Staffing shortages have pushed absentee rates sharply higher, leaving major airports scrambling to maintain basic operations as spring travel ramps up.

At hubs like Houston , Atlanta and New York, wait times have ballooned to hours, with viral videos showing passengers winding through snaking lines

that stretch far beyond normal TSA checkpoints. The disruptions have become one of the most visible signs of the shutdown's real-world impact.

In response, President Donald Trump signed an executive order to ensure TSA agents are paid, an emergency measure aimed at stabilizing the workforce before conditions deteriorate further. But the move does little to resolve the underlying funding fight and raises new questions about how long such payments can continue without congressional action.

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Meanwhile, attempts to plug the gaps have taken on a surreal quality. Immigration and Customs Enforcement personnel have been deployed to assist at airports, even as the agency itself remains at the center of the political standoff.

The broader picture is increasingly hard to ignore: a fight in Washington over immigration security policy has morphed into a nationwide disruption, where the dysfunction is no longer confined to Capitol Hill but playing out in real time, in security lines that show no clear end in sight.

Read more

about this topic

ICE at the airport is just the beginning

"No more games": Trump threatens to deploy ICE at airports amid government shutdown

DHS to shut down, but ICE

At hubs like Houston , Atlanta and New York, wait times have ballooned to hours, with viral videos showing passengers winding through snaking lines that stretch far beyond normal TSA checkpoints.

CK Smith

“No blank check for a lawless ICE”: House rejects Senate plan to fund TSA without ICE

Jelinda Montes · Salon

The U. S. Senate voted early Friday to partially fund the Department of Homeland Security , providing much needed relief to the Transportation Security Administration and travelers across the country. Notably, the funding excluded immigration enforcement groups like Border Patrol and Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

“In the wake of the murders of Renee Good and Alex Pretti, Senate Democrats were clear. No blank check for a lawless ICE and Border Patrol,” Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer , D-N. Y., said to press following the vote.

Schumer said the funding “could have been accomplished weeks ago if Republicans hadn’t stood in the way.”

DHS funding lapse fuels fear of domestic attacks

Senate Majority Leader John Thune , R-S. D., took his own shot at the other side of the aisle after the vote. “President Trump should never have had to step in to rescue TSA workers and U. S. air travel. We are here because, thanks to Democrats’ determined refusal to reach an agreement, there will be no Homeland Security funding bill this year,” he said.

TSA, the Coast Guard, the Federal Emergency Management Agency and the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency will all receive funding from this bill. The deadlock on immigration enforcement reforms remains stagnant with Democrats’ demands for ICE agents to stop masking their faces and provide judicial warrants on arrests still unfulfilled. The newly appointed DHS secretary, Markwayne Mullin , who replaced Kristi Noem , said he’s open to ending administrative warrants.

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House Speaker Mike Johnson , R-La., met with the Freedom Caucus, the ultra-conservative coalition of Republican representatives, to discuss the bill. Rep. Chip Roy , R-Texas, called the bill an “absurdity,” and the Freedom Caucus is likely to hold up the bill using it as leverage to pass the Senate-stalled voter ID bill, the SAVE America Act, which could substantially change how millions of Americans vote before the 2026 midterms .

The bill was almost immediately rejected by the House of Representatives on Friday. Instead, they offered an alternative plan that included funding for all of DHS, including ICE, according to reporting from the Washington Post .

“The bottom line is, this deal is bad for Americans,” House Freedom Caucus Chairman Andy Harris, R-Md., told reporters Friday.

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SCOTUS set to deal major blow to mail voting ahead of midterms

Environmental groups and states sue EPA over Trump’s emissions rollback

The conservative woman cracking down on conservative women

The post “No blank check for a lawless ICE”: House rejects Senate plan to fund TSA without ICE appeared first on Salon.com .

BRIEFS

IN BRIEF

Esraa Abo Qamar, The Nation: Esraa Abo Qamar

For these medical students in Gaza, completing their studies was an act of defiance.

The post “I Refused to Let the Genocide Steal My Dreams” appeared first on The Nation .

Harrison Stetler, The Nation: Harrison Stetler

Barring a few big-ticket victories in this month’s local elections, the French left is more divided than ever—one year from a pivotal fight for the presidency

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By Kiley Price, Inside Climate News: Citing national security, the Trump administration wants to exempt all federally regulated offshore oil from protections for endangered animals—even if it could cause their extinction.

By Kiley Price

The Trump administration is turning to the nuclear option on endangered-species protections in the name of national security.

Anthony Conwright, The Nation: Anthony Conwright

After you strip away the lies about rampant voter fraud, the GOP bill is a frontal assault on hard-won protections of the franchise.

The post How the SAVE Act Seeks to Undermine the Right to Vote appeared first on The Nation .

Pepper Stetler, The Nation: Pepper Stetler

Gregory Javier Laguna, who has Down syndrome, and his brother have been detained for almost five months. Under Trump, “it feels like we have no recourse,” said one advocate.

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BBC News, BBC News: The Israeli PM said Cardinal Pierbattista Pizzaballa had been asked not to enter the church out of concern for his safety.

BBC News, BBC News: Having recovered from brain surgery and battled PTSD, an emotional Gary Woodland seals his first win in seven years at the Houston Open.

Car and Driver, Car and Driver: They’ll join a new plug-in-hybrid model and a body-on-frame pickup, which are both scheduled to arrive in the next three years.

BBC News, BBC News: Fans believe VAR is ruining goal celebrations and has not improved football since its introduction, according to a Football Supporters’ Association survey.

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